



CITY: Pg 3

‘Green Budget’ passed in dramatic finale



NATION: Pg 5

Jan Vishwas Bill’s 2nd edition introduced in LS



FILM: Pg 14

Aamir opens up about ‘Sitaare Zameen Par’ OTT release

SLAPS WINDFALL TAX ON FUEL EXPORTS

Govt cuts excise duty on petrol, diesel; rates to be reviewed every fortnight

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The excise duty cut on petrol and diesel by Rs 10/litre, and a hike in export duty on ATF and diesel will result in a net revenue loss of Rs 5,500 crore in a fortnight, according to Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) Chairman Vivek Chaturvedi.

He said the excise duty cut will result in a revenue loss of around Rs 7,000 crore, while the hike in special additional excise duty on export of diesel and ATF will fetch Rs 1,500 crore more in a fortnight.

After reduction in excise duty, the incidence of excise on petrol will be Rs 11.9 per litre (Rs 1.40 basic excise duty, Rs 3 special additional excise duty, Rs 2.50 agriculture infrastructure and development cess, and Rs 5 road infrastructure cess).

On diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF), an export duty of Rs 21.5 per litre and Rs 29.5 per litre has been imposed effective March 26.

The rates will be reviewed on a fortnightly basis.

The move to levy export duty on diesel and ATF is to “prioritise domestic availability of diesel and ATF and “ensure



Consumers throng at a petrol station amid rumours of fuel shortages due to war, in Thane, Friday PTI

energy security for the country in the midst of global uncertainty which has been exacerbated by a disruption in supply chain”, Chaturvedi said at a media briefing.

Excise duty cut on petrol, diesel is aimed at reducing under-recoveries of oil marketing companies (OMCs) and ensuring prices do not rise for consumers on account of the ongoing crisis, he said.

“The situation is dynamic, it

is not business as usual where you would have a predictability that certain metric tonne of goods will come. We are living in difficult times. Any (revenue) implication will have to factor in actual supply of goods coming into the country”, Chaturvedi said.

The excise duty cuts follow record losses that oil companies suffered from the surge in international oil prices. Prices of crude oil, the raw material

for making petrol and diesel, have surged almost 50 per cent this month as the US and Israel attack on Iran and Tehran’s sweeping retaliation disrupts global supply.

Despite oil prices rising above USD 100 per barrel, retail pump rates had remained on freeze. This had led to oil companies incurring record losses which had even started impacting their working capital.

TAKEAWAYS

- » The Centre’s cut of Rs 10 per litre excise duty on petrol and diesel will lead to a revenue loss of about Rs 7,000 crore in a fortnight
- » A simultaneous increase in export duty on diesel and ATF is expected to generate Rs 1,500 crore, limiting the net loss to Rs 5,500 crore
- » Post-cut, total excise incidence on petrol stands at Rs 11.9 per litre, including basic excise, special additional duty, agriculture cess and road cess
- » The government has imposed export duties of Rs 21.5/litre on diesel and Rs 29.5/litre on ATF, effective March 26

since April 2022 despite geopolitical shocks -- from the Russia-Ukraine war to the Middle East crisis -- that have driven sharp swings in global oil prices. The country depends on imports for 88 per cent of its crude oil needs.

In contrast, fuel prices have risen by 30-50 per cent across South and Southeast Asian countries, 30 per cent in North America, and 20 per cent in Europe since the onset of the current crisis.

Considering 175 billion litres of auto fuel sales annually (115 billion litres of diesel and 60 billion litres of petrol), the impact of the duty cut would be Rs 1.75 lakh crore annually, according to industry estimates.

State-owned fuel retailers, who control about 90 per cent of the market, continue to keep rates unchanged at Rs 94.77 a litre for petrol in Delhi and Rs 87.67 per litre for diesel.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in a post on X said the reduction in excise duty “will provide protection to consumers from rise in prices”.

The government, she said, has always ensured that citizens are protected from vagaries of supply and costs of essential goods.

West Asia conflict: PM interacts with CMs, bats for ‘Team India’ spirit

Imposing lockdown not even under discussion, says Govt

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Amid evolving situation in West Asia, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday chaired a high-level meeting with Chief Ministers and Lieutenant Governors of all but poll-bound states to review India’s preparedness while stressing the need for vigilance, coordination and swift response to emerging challenges.

Addressing the meeting via video conferencing, the Prime Minister expressed confidence that the country would overcome the situation through a “Team India” approach, recalling how coordinated Centre-State action helped mitigate disruptions during the Covid-19 pandemic.

He said the situation remains dynamic and requires continuous monitoring, noting that an inter-ministerial group has been reviewing developments daily since March 3.

PM Modi outlined the government’s key priorities — maintaining economic and trade stability, ensuring energy security, safeguarding citizens’ interests, and strengthening industry and



Prime Minister Narendra Modi chairs a virtual meeting PTI

KEY POINTS

- » He stressed vigilance, coordination, and quick response, calling for a “Team India” approach similar to the Covid-19 period
- » Key priorities outlined: economic and trade stability, energy security, citizen safety, and strengthening supply chains
- » States were directed to ensure smooth supply chains and act strictly against hoarding and profiteering

supply chains — amid global uncertainties.

Emphasising the role of states, PM Modi urged them to ensure Continued on P4

Quick News

HC REJECTS PLEA FOR CBI PROBE INTO BRIBERY ALLEGATIONS AGAINST ADANI GREEN ENERGY

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Friday rejected a petition seeking a Central Bureau of Investigation probe into allegations of large-scale bribery involving Adani Green Energy Ltd and its associates in securing solar power contracts across multiple states.

A division bench of Chief Justice Shree Chandreshkar and Justice Suman Shyam dismissed the plea filed by Silvassa resident Jitendra P Maru, 61, who had sought directions for the CBI to register an FIR under the Prevention of Corruption Act. Maru’s petition relied on material from a United States criminal indictment and parallel proceedings before the Securities and Exchange Commission, both pending in a New York court. He alleged an organised scheme involving Adani Green Energy and Continued on P4

ALLAHABAD HC SAYS MARRIED MAN’S CONSENSUAL LIVE-IN RELATIONSHIP NOT A CRIME

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad High Court has held that a married man living in a consensual live-in relationship with an adult woman does not constitute a criminal offence while granting interim protection to a couple from Uttar Pradesh’s Shahjahanpur who alleged threats from the woman’s family.

A Division Bench of Justice JJ Munir and Justice Tarun Saxena made the observation while hearing a criminal writ petition filed by the couple seeking quashing of an FIR lodged by the woman’s mother. The FIR, registered on January 8 at Jaitipur police station under Section 87 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, accused the man, Netrapal, of enticing the woman, Anamika, away from her home with assistance from another individual.

During the proceedings, the court noted that the woman is 18 years old and had informed authorities that she is living Continued on P4

TEHSILDAR, WHO ONCE WON RS 50 LAKH ON KBC, ARRESTED IN RS 2.6 CR FLOOD RELIEF SCAM

NEW DELHI: A woman tehsildar who once drew national attention after winning Rs 50 lakh on popular television quiz show ‘Kaun Banega Crorepati’ in 2011 has been arrested in Madhya Pradesh’s Gwalior over alleged embezzlement of flood relief funds amounting to Rs 2.57 crore. Police took Amita Singh Tomar into custody on Thursday following the rejection of her pre-arrest bail plea.

The case dates back to 2021, when Tomar was posted as tehsildar in Baroda and oversaw the distribution of relief funds in Sheopur district after flooding. According to investigators, she, along with nearly 25 patwaris and over 100 middlemen, diverted funds by routing money into 127 fake bank accounts.

The alleged fraud came to light during an audit ordered by the Baroda Deputy Collector. Subsequent findings led to the registration of an FIR, triggering a detailed Continued on P4

Attacks on Iran ‘will escalate’, says Israel as Trump claims advances in talks

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Israel threatened to “escalate and expand” its attacks on Iran on Friday, even as US President Donald Trump claimed talks on ending the war were going well and gave Tehran more time to open the Strait of Hormuz. Iran, meanwhile, gave no signs of backing down.

With stock markets reeling and economic fallout from the war extending far beyond the Middle East, Trump is under growing pressure to end Iran’s

chokehold on the strait, a strategic waterway through which a fifth of the world’s oil is usually shipped.

Iran has rejected a 15-point US proposal for a ceasefire that includes it relinquishing control of the strait but at the same time has ordered thousands more troops to the region — possibly in preparation for a military attempt to wrest the waterway from Iran.

Trump has said if Iran doesn’t reopen the strait to all traffic by April 6, he will order the destruction of Iran’s energy plants. He



said Thursday that talks on ending the conflict were going “very well.” Iran maintains it is not engaged in any negotiations.

MODI CONGRATULATES BALENDRA SHAH

Nepal gets youngest-ever elected PM as Balendra ‘Balen’ Shah takes oath

MPOST BUREAU

KATHMANDU/NEW DELHI: Balendra Shah, widely known as ‘Balen’, was sworn in as Nepal’s prime minister on Friday, marking a historic political transition in the Himalayan nation as a new generation of leadership takes charge following months of upheaval. At 35, Shah becomes the youngest democratically elected leader to assume the office, capping a dramatic rise from rapper and engineer to national leadership after a youth-driven political movement reshaped the coun-



Newly appointed Prime Minister of Nepal, Balendra Shah, during his swearing-in ceremony, at the President’s residence, in Kathmandu, Nepal, Friday PTI

try’s power structure.

The oath of office was administered by President

Ram Chandra Paudel at the President’s Office in Sheela Niwas at 12.34 pm. Shah leads the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), which secured a sweeping mandate in the March 5 parliamentary elections, winning 182 out of 275 seats in the House of Representatives and enabling it to form a majority government.

Shah’s ascent comes around six months after the collapse of the government led by KP Sharma Oli, which was ousted in September last year amid a Gen Z-led protest movement.

Continued on P4

Tragedy at Zojila Pass: 7 dead after snow slides bury vehicles

MPOST BUREAU

SRINAGAR: Seven people lost their lives and five others were injured after multiple avalanches struck the Srinagar-Leh National Highway near Zojila Pass in Jammu and Kashmir on Friday, trapping vehicles under heavy snow and triggering an urgent rescue operation, officials said.

The avalanches hit the stretch between Zero Point and Minimarg in the afternoon, leaving several vehicles buried beneath snow and debris. Rescue teams were deployed immediately, working to clear the route and pull out those trapped. Authorities said efforts were ongoing to ensure the safety of stranded travellers and provide medical assistance to the injured.

Union minister Jitendra Singh confirmed the casualties, saying, “Saddened to learn about the tragic death of 7 persons and injuries to 5 after an avalanche hit the vehicle at Zojila Pass.” He added that all necessary assistance was being extended to those affected.

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha reviewed the rescue and relief operations and spoke with senior officials to monitor the situation. According to an official spokesperson, he directed authorities to prioritise the safety of those stranded and Continued on P4

NOD FOR MTA, S-400, DHANUSH AND MORE

DAC clears Rs 2.38 lakh cr defence deals

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: India on Friday cleared a sweeping set of defence procurement proposals worth about Rs 2.38 lakh crore, with the Defence Acquisition Council (DAC) granting Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for a range of platforms aimed at strengthening the operational readiness of the Air Force, Army and Coast Guard. The approvals, granted at a meeting chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh in New Delhi, include new batches of S-400 air defence systems, medium transport aircraft, artillery guns and surveillance capabilities, marking one of the largest single-day clearances in recent years.

The council, the defence ministry’s apex body for capital

CLOSER LOOK

- » Approvals cover S-400 systems, transport aircraft, artillery and surveillance platforms
- » IAF to replace AN-32, IL-76 fleet; 12 aircraft imported, 48 made in India
- » Five more S-400 units cleared under follow-on to

acquisitions, approved proposals spanning air defence, mobility, communication and surveillance systems. Officials described the clearances as part of a broader push to modernise ageing fleets and plug operational gaps across services.

A major component of the approvals relates to the Indian Air Force’s plan to induct 60 medium transport aircraft to replace its

ageing Soviet-origin AN-32 and IL-76 fleet. These aircraft are expected to have a payload capacity of 18 to 30 tonnes and will address strategic and tactical airlift requirements. According to sources, 12 aircraft are likely to be acquired in fly-away condition, while 48 will be manufactured in India, aligning with domestic production goals.

The multi-billion programme

has drawn interest from global manufacturers. Contenders include Lockheed Martin’s C-130J Super Hercules, already in service with the IAF, Embraer’s KC-390 Millennium, and Airbus Defence and Space’s A-400M Atlas, each offering varying payload capacities and operational roles.

In parallel, the DAC cleared procurement of an additional batch of S-400 long-range sur-

2018 \$5 billion Russia deal

- » Clearance given for remotely piloted strike aircraft and overhaul of Su-30 engines
- » Army to get air defence systems, Dhanush guns, anti-tank ammunition and surveillance gear
- » Coast Guard to procure heavy-duty air cushion vehicles for patrol and rescue

face-to-air missile systems from Russia. While the ministry did not specify numbers, sources indicated that five additional units have been approved. India had signed a USD 5 billion deal in October 2018 for five S-400 systems, of which three squadrons have already been delivered.

The S-400 systems are designed to counter long-range aerial threats targeting critical infrastructure. Their performance during Operation Sindoor, particularly in the May 7 to 10 hostilities last year, was cited by officials as a factor in the decision to expand the inventory. The new order is expected to be treated as a follow-on to the earlier contract, with no anticipated complications from US sanctions under CAATSA.

Continued on P4

Five-tier security, 5,000 personnel for Noida Int’l Airport inauguration

Elaborate security, emergency preparedness and traffic diversions for launch

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: A comprehensive five-tier security arrangement has been put in place and around 5,000 personnel deployed for the inauguration of the Noida International Airport at Jewar by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday, with authorities also enforcing traffic restrictions and diversions across Noida and Greater Noida to ensure smooth movement during the high-profile event.

According to officials, the venue and surrounding areas have been secured under a multi-layered security architecture in coordination with the Special Protection Group (SPG). Extensive checks, including anti-sabotage sweeps, bomb disposal squad inspections and anti-mine operations, have been carried out in advance.

Strict access control measures will be enforced at all entry points, with mandatory frisking, baggage screening and identity verification. Invitations issued for the event specify that wearing black clothing and



live streaming of the programme are prohibited.

Security deployment includes personnel from multiple agencies such as PAC, RAF, ATS and CISE, supported by Quick Reaction Teams stationed at strategic locations. Door Frame Metal Detectors have been installed at various points, along with separate enclosures for women attendees.

The area has been declared a red zone with a complete ban on drone operations, and anti-drone teams have been deployed. Authorities are also

monitoring social media platforms to track misinformation and potential threats. A central control room has been set up for CCTV surveillance, while help desks will assist attendees at designated points.

Emergency preparedness has been strengthened through coordination with NDRF and SDRF teams. Fire tenders are on standby, evacuation routes have been marked, and mock drills conducted. Medical support will include ambulances, dedicated corridors for emergency movement and on-site medical desks.

TAKEAWAYS

- » Traffic restrictions will be enforced across key routes, particularly along the Yamuna Expressway and roads connecting Noida and Greater Noida to Jewar
- » Vehicular movement on certain stretches of the expressway will be regulated intermittently during VIP movement

during VIP movement.

Heavy vehicles, including trucks and commercial carriers, will be barred from designated stretches during specific hours and diverted via alternative routes identified by the administration. Light motor vehicles may also be rerouted depending on congestion and security requirements.

Authorities have arranged parking for nearly 20,000 vehicles across 15 designated sites, and traffic personnel will be deployed at major intersections to manage flow and assist commuters.

Officials have advised residents to avoid non-essential travel towards Jewar and adjoining areas during peak hours, warning of heavy congestion, especially during the event window. Commuters travelling between Noida and Agra have been advised to allow extra time and check real-time traffic updates. Authorities have also planned phased crowd dispersal and traffic clearance measures to ensure smooth movement and an incident-free airport inauguration event.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

BAWANA MURDER CASE Tillu gang sharpshooters arrested after encounter

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Three members of the Tillu Tajpuria gang have been arrested, two of them after a brief encounter in outer Delhi’s Rohini, in connection with the Ravi Bhardwaj murder earlier this month in Bawana, officials said on Friday.

Those arrested have been identified as Chetanya (22), Kunal alias Shunty (23) and a juvenile. While Chetanya was earlier apprehended during the investigation, Kunal and the juvenile were held after an encounter with the Crime Branch in Rohini Sector 28, they said.

According to the police, the encounter took place around 12.50 am on March 26 when a Crime Branch team intercepted the duo riding a scooter. On seeing the police, the accused allegedly fired indiscriminately, prompting retaliatory action. Both sustained bullet injuries in their legs and were overpowered.

During the exchange of fire, Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) Sanjay Kumar Nagpal and a head constable were also hit, but escaped unhurt due to their bulletproof jackets, a senior



police officer said.

Two semi-automatic pistols along with seven live cartridges, eight empty shells and a stolen scooter were recovered. A tempo used in the crime has also been traced, they added.

The arrests come in connection with the March 19 killing of Bhardwaj, a resident of Harevelli village in Bawana, who was shot dead inside his house. Three others, including his father, were injured in the firing. The attack is suspected to be part of an ongoing gang rivalry between the Gogi and Tillu gangs.

During investigation, Chetanya emerged as a key conspirator who allegedly provided the shooters with details about the victim’s residence and movements and even pointed out the target prior to the attack. He was in touch with other conspirators through mobile communication and later deleted incriminating data, police said.

Based on his disclosures and technical evidence, police identified the shooters, including Kunal and the juvenile, who were directly involved in carrying out the killing. The assailants had reached the spot on two motorcycles and opened fire in a coordinated manner, killing Bhardwaj on the spot and injuring three others.

Police said the crime was executed on the directions of gang members linked to Deepak Pakasma and Himmat alias Chiku, who are currently leading the Tillu gang. Tarun alias Tori emerged as a key conspirator linking shooters and informer. Police arrested main shooter Akash alias Bittu in Begusarai. A Tillu Tajpuria gang operative, he was involved in a retaliatory killing in the Gogi-Tillu gang rivalry.

Delhi Police continues to top chart on ‘Pragati Dashboard’ in crime tracking

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has retained the top position among all states and Union Territories on the CCTNS Pragati Dashboard, reflecting its performance in technology-driven policing and data management, officials said on Friday.

The force had earlier recorded a perfect score for three consecutive months



Force had earlier recorded a perfect score for 3 months

from October to December

last year and continued its strong performance by ranking first in January and February, they said.

The Crime and Criminal Tracking Network & Systems (CCTNS) Pragati Dashboard, monitored by the Ministry of Home Affairs and the National Crime Records Bureau, evaluates states on parameters such as data quality, timeliness, connectivity of police stations and delivery of citizen services.

Father-son duo caught as Delhi Police bust illegal LPG hoarding, refilling racket, 50 cylinders seized

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have busted an illegal LPG hoarding and refilling racket in outer Delhi, arresting two people and seizing 50 cylinders along with equipment used in the operation, an official said on Friday.

The police conducted coordinated raids in the Sukhbir Nagar and Rama Vihar areas in the Rohini district on Thursday, uncovering unauthorised storage and refilling of domestic



LPG cylinders, he said.

During the raids, the police arrested Kunwar Pal, 55, and his son, Pankaj Pal, 21, both residents of Sukhbir Nagar,

they said. The police recovered a total of 50 Indane LPG cylinders, including 29 filled and 21 empty ones. Besides, they also seized a tempo used for transportation and a weighing scale, they said. The police have registered a case under the relevant sections of the Essential Commodities Act and BNS.

According to the police, Kunwar Pal worked as an authorised delivery personnel with an LPG gas agency and

was responsible for distribution in the Rama Vihar area.

However, instead of delivering the cylinders, he allegedly diverted and stored them illegally at his premises. During interrogation, the accused revealed that they were refilling gas from filled cylinders into empty ones using unauthorised equipment and selling them in the open market at inflated prices, taking advantage of demand, police said.

MPOST

Chemical engineer stabs fellow inmate to death at rehab centre

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A chemical engineer undergoing treatment at a de-addiction centre in outer north Delhi’s Hiranki area allegedly stabbed his fellow inmate to death on Friday, police said.

The incident took place at “Kirandeep Foundation” located at Kashmiri Colony, police said in a statement.

An intimation regarding a stabbing incident was received at Alipur police station, following which a team rushed to the spot and found blood scattered on the premises, they said.

“Inquiries revealed that the injured had already been shifted to a hospital in Burari, where he was declared brought dead. The deceased was identified as Arun Kumar (22), a resident of Satya Vihar in Burari,” an officer said.

According to the police, Kumar came from an economically weak background, and his father works as a rickshaw driver.

Family members informed police that he had developed a drug addiction during his teenage years and was admitted to the rehabilitation centre for treatment.

A case was registered, and an investigation was taken up. The officer said that a team was constituted immediately to identify and apprehend the accused. Acting swiftly, the police found the accused, identified as Arun Joshi (27), present at the spot and took him into custody.

Joshi, a resident of Tri Nagar, was also undergoing treatment at the same de-addiction centre, police said. The weapon of offence -- a blood-stained knife -- was recovered from his possession.

During interrogation, Joshi disclosed that he had a quarrel with Kumar a few days prior

KEY POINTS

- » Further investigation revealed that around 27 drug addicts are currently admitted at the rehab centre where the incident occurred
- » Police said CCTV footage from the premises has been seized, which captures the presence, involvement of accused
- » Blood samples and other biological evidence have also been collected from the scene to corroborate the sequence of events: Cops

to the incident, they said, adding that the altercation escalated after Kumar hurled some abusive words at him, following which Joshi attacked him to take revenge.

“Further investigation revealed that around 27 drug addicts are currently admitted at the rehabilitation centre where the incident occurred. Police said CCTV footage from the premises has been seized, which captures the presence and involvement of the accused. Blood samples and other biological evidence have also been collected from the scene to corroborate the sequence of events,” the officer added.

“The accused, who holds a degree in chemical engineering from a Delhi-based institute, had developed a habit of consuming cannabis during his college years and had been admitted to the centre around nine months ago for rehabilitation,” the officer said.

Police said further investigation is underway to ascertain all aspects of the case, including any possible lapses at the facility.

City boosts commercial LPG supply, assures no shortage

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has increased commercial LPG allocation to 70 per cent of previous levels following directives from the Centre, aiming to stabilise supply and ensure smooth operations across industries and the hospitality sector.

Announcing the revised allocation, Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the move includes an additional 20 per cent supply over the earlier 50 per cent cap, taking total daily availability to around 6,300 cylinders of 19 kg, compared to the normal consumption of 9,000 cylinders.

“Delhi’s industries and eateries can now operate without disruption, this 70 per cent allocation is a direct result of coordinated efforts at the Centre and state level,” Sirsa said.

The updated distribution prioritises labour-intensive



industries such as steel, automobile, textile, chemicals, plastics and pharma, which now receive about 1,800 cylinders daily, especially where LPG cannot be replaced by piped natural gas (PNG). The hospitality sector, including hotels, restaurants, dhabas, food processing units and dairies, has been allocated the largest share of 3,375 cylinders per day.

Essential services such as education, healthcare, railways, airports and buses have been allotted 225 cylinders daily, while caterers, banquets, government institutions and community kitchens also receive dedicated quotas. Additionally, 5 kg cylinders have been earmarked for migrant workers and students to ensure accessibility.

The minister dismissed concerns over shortages, stating, “There is absolutely no shortage; supplies are stable thanks to proactive measures,” adding that monitoring has shown no signs of panic buying or hoarding in the city.

He also urged consumers to avoid misinformation, saying, “Rumours related to availability of LPG in Delhi are baseless and not to be encouraged.”

Highlighting coordination, Sirsa thanked PM Narendra Modi and CM Rekha Gupta. Officials said the revised order builds on measures ensuring supply to essential services and priority booking, while urging users to shift to PNG where feasible.

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AIIMS surgeons remove 21.8 kg uterine sarcoma tumour in high-risk operation

Massive 45 cm tumour compressing vital organs successfully excised

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Doctors at AIIMS Delhi’s Dr B R Ambekar Institute Rotary Cancer Hospital (Dr BRA-IRCH) successfully removed a massive 21.8-kg tumour from a 46-year-old woman diagnosed with advanced uterine sarcoma this week.

The Delhi resident, who was also recently diagnosed with diabetes and hypertension, had endured progressive abdominal fullness for four months, followed by severe distension, pain, and functional limitations over the last three months. However, she reported no bowel or bladder issues.



After receiving initial symptomatic treatment, she underwent evaluation and was found to have a gigantic mass filling her entire abdomen and pelvis, according to Dr M D Ray, a professor in the Department of Surgical Oncology at Dr BRA-IRCH.

“On examination, we found a tumour measuring approximately 45 cm, occupying the whole abdomen,” Dr Ray said.

“The operation carried high risks, including potential rupture of major vessels and massive haemorrhage”

The rapidly growing mass was compressing vital organs like the kidneys and ureters, risking renal failure within a month or two. It also triggered lower back pain, walking difficulties, and respiratory distress.

On March 23, the team performed an exploratory laparotomy, which revealed the tumour’s origin in the uterus. Surgeons excised the uterus, ovaries, fallopian tubes, and the

enormous tumour in a grueling five-hour procedure.

The operation carried high risks, including potential rupture of major vessels and massive haemorrhage leading to shock, Dr Ray explained.

Yet, blood loss was limited to 500 ml, managed with one unit of packed red blood cells (PRBC) intraoperatively.

Post-surgery, the patient was shifted to ICU for monitoring, with anaesthetist Dr Rakesh Garg overseeing care. She began walking the next day and is recovering well, likely to be discharged soon. Doctors said even massive tumours can be effectively treated with expert care.

Woman, accomplice held for orchestrating husband’s stabbing

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 24-year-old woman and her accomplice have been arrested by Delhi Police for allegedly conspiring to stab her husband and fabricating a false story to mislead investigators in Patel Nagar.

Police said the case came to light on March 24 after a PCR call and information from RML Hospital about a man admitted with multiple stab injuries. The victim remains under treatment and was declared unfit for statement. The accused were identified as Laxmi (24), the victim’s wife, and Karan (22) of Baljeet Nagar. Initially, Laxmi told police that her husband had been attacked by unidentified

persons in a nearby park.

However, CCTV footage analysis revealed inconsistencies in her account. Sustained interrogation led to the disclosure that she had allegedly conspired with Karan, an acquaintance of two to three years, to attack her husband.

Police said marital disputes and financial issues were the motive. On the day of the incident, Laxmi allegedly called Karan to her residence, where he stabbed the victim multiple times following a confrontation. Karan was nabbed on March 25 from near Shadipur Flyover, and Laxmi was later arrested. The knife used in the crime has been recovered.

THE ERA OF EXCUSES IS OVER - IT'S TIME FOR RESULTS: CM REKHA GUPTA

Green Budget passed in dramatic finale

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a dramatic finale to the Budget Session, the Delhi Assembly on Friday unanimously passed the 2026–27 “Green Budget,” even as the House witnessed sharp political exchanges, major institutional actions, and a serious security alert. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta set the tone, declaring, “The era of excuses is over - it’s time for results,” signalling a shift towards accountability-driven governance.

Budget cleared

Outlining her government’s priorities, Gupta said, “This is a new government with a new way of working. The focus will be on delivery,” adding, “Delhi will no longer remain stuck. It will move forward rapidly and set an example for the country.” Calling it the highest-ever capital expenditure budget, she stressed that it aims for “real, on-ground development.” She asserted, “Every rupee will be



accounted for, every project delivered,” while highlighting a Rs 47,000 crore “debt legacy,” with Rs 27,547 crore still outstanding. She detailed pending liabilities, including Rs 3,700 crore in expressways, Rs 9,087 crore in metro projects, over Rs 2,000 crore in hospitals, and Rs 1,031 crore in DMRC-PWD works. The government has begun clearing dues, including Rs 114 crore in tuition fees for SC/ST/OBC students and Rs 538 crore for colleges, along with payments related

to EWS welfare, scholarships and sportspersons. Gupta also alleged irregularities, claiming Rs 250 crore was paid in a PWD project “without any work being completed.”

Opposition targeted

Targeting the Opposition, Gupta said, “They were given a full opportunity to speak inside the Assembly but chose to sit on the streets instead.” On borrowing, she clarified, “Loans are not new,” adding, “our government has maintained fiscal

discipline,” with borrowings at just 1.17 per cent of GSDP at 7.4 per cent interest. She further flagged losses of Rs 99,000 crore in DTC and Rs 91,000 crore in DJB, calling the water billing system “dysfunctional.”

3rd consecutive bomb threat

Amid proceedings, Speaker Vijender Gupta informed the House that the Assembly received its third bomb threat email between March 24 and March 26. Calling the matter serious, he said police have been directed to act “without any laxity.” Security has been intensified with enhanced CCTV surveillance and a computerised entry system to ensure better monitoring.

‘Phansi-ghar’ row

In a significant resolution, the Assembly issued a formal warning to former CM Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia, Ram Niwas Goyal and Rakhi Birla over spreading a “manufactured and baseless narrative”

regarding a ‘Phansi Ghar’ inside the Assembly. Speaker Gupta said, “The contempt has been proven,” adding, “While no court in India can grant relief in matters of legislative privilege, we are proceeding based on the dignity of this institution.” He termed linking the Assembly to an execution chamber a “disservice,” recalling its historic legacy, including Mahatma Gandhi’s visit during the Rowlatt Bill debate.

Special mentions by MLAs

Addressing concerns raised by MLAs over lack of responses from departments, Speaker Gupta assured that issues would be properly resolved. “The procedure is that such replies are sent to the Committee on Questions and References, which summons officers and the MLA concerned for resolution of the issue,” he said.

CAG reports

Discussions on multiple CAG reports dominated pro-

ceedings. Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said, “The CAG report clearly establishes that this was not a policy error but a deliberate design,” alleging over Rs 2,000 crore loss in the excise policy and calling it a “cartel-driven system.” Higher Education Minister Ashish Sood stated, “These are not my words—these findings come from the report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India,” highlighting failures in university planning, admissions and infrastructure. Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said, “These are not allegations. These are findings recorded by the CAG,” adding, “Delhi does not lack water. ...Delhi suffered from lack of planning.”

Yamuna, water mismanagement

Yamuna pollution and water mismanagement emerged as key issues in the Assembly, with Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh stating, “These are not allegations. These are findings recorded by the CAG.”

CM Gupta raps AAP over debt and dues

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Assembly on Friday passed the Rs 1.03 lakh crore Budget for 2026–27 with a voice vote, as Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched a sharp attack on the previous AAP government, accusing it of leaving behind massive debt and pending liabilities.

Speaking during the motion of thanks, Gupta said her government has inherited loans exceeding Rs 47,000 crore. “During their tenure, the loan increased to more than Rs 47,000 crore,” she told the House, adding that her administration is now working to repay the burden. She also defended her government’s borrowing, stating it secured loans at a lower interest rate of 7.4 per cent.

The Budget, tabled earlier this week, was passed in the absence of AAP MLAs, who boycotted the session. Highlighting financial liabilities, the Chief Minister listed Rs 3,700 crore pending for expressway

projects and over Rs 9,000 crore for metro expansion, of which Rs 2,700 crore has already been cleared. She further noted dues of over Rs 2,000 crore in health infrastructure and more than Rs 1,000 crore in education projects. Expressing strong criticism, Gupta said, “I feel ashamed thinking about what kind of government it was,” alleging that funds meant for welfare schemes, sports awards and economically weaker sections were not released. She added that her government has cleared Rs 1,750 crore in scholarships, Rs 14.5 crore in pending awards and dues under the Kishori scheme. Taking a political swipe, she remarked, “They were like TB for Delhi, clinging to the lungs of the city,” while alleging corruption and mismanagement during the previous regime.

The Chief Minister also flagged mounting losses in public bodies, stating that the Delhi Transport Corporation and Delhi Jal Board are running deficits of Rs 99,000 crore and Rs 91,000 crore respectively.

Weather swings: Hot morning, cool cameo



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The national capital on Friday recorded its hottest morning of the year, even as parts of the city witnessed light rainfall during the day, as the maximum temperature settled at 32.6 degrees Celsius.

The minimum temperature settled at 20.6 degrees Celsius, making it the warmest morning of this year. The last time a higher minimum temperature was recorded was on March 13, when it stood at 20.4 degrees Celsius, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). Light rainfall was recorded across the city between morning and 5:30 pm, with Safdarjung logging 0.7 mm, Ridge 1.2 mm, and trace rainfall reported in other areas.

Station-wise data showed Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 30.8 degrees Celsius, 1.9 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road logged 31.4 degrees Celsius, 0.6 degrees below normal, while the Ridge station recorded 32.9 degrees Celsius, 0.5 degrees below normal. Ayanagar recorded 31.6 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degrees below normal.

The weather office has predicted partly cloudy skies for Saturday, with the minimum temperature likely to settle at 18 degrees Celsius and the maximum around 32 degrees Celsius.

According to IMD officials, the ongoing spell of unusual

weather in March is linked to a series of western disturbances affecting northwest India. These systems have been influencing the region since March 15 and are approaching at a lower altitude than usual, thereby impacting weather patterns over Delhi.

As a result, isolated parts of the city may experience high wind speeds, light rain and mild dust storms during the day. However, the current weather activity is unlikely to have any significant impact on temperatures, officials said.

Explaining the outlook, Mahesh Palawat of Skymet said rainfall activity is likely towards the end of the month.

“Between March 29 and 31, widespread rainfall activity is likely across large parts of India. This extended spell is expected to bring down temperatures, with daytime readings likely to settle in the mid-20s degrees Celsius towards the end of March,” he said.

On the minimum temperature front, Safdarjung recorded 20.6 degrees Celsius. Among other stations, Palam reported 19.6 degrees Celsius, 1.9 degrees above normal, Lodhi Road recorded 19.2 degrees Celsius, 3.2 degrees above normal, and Ridge logged 19.9 degrees Celsius, 0.3 degrees above normal.

Meanwhile, Delhi’s Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 141, falling in the ‘moderate’ category, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

New domestic borewell policy on anvil: Delhi Water minister

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is working on a new domestic borewell policy in the national capital with some of the red tape removed, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma said on Friday.

Making his statement in the Budget Session of the Delhi Assembly, the minister said that under the policy, permissions will be given to domestic consumers for a small fee.

“Currently, many illegal borewells are operating in the city. Notices are served to people. Also, there are several permissions required to set up a borewell. We will end all this. Soon, the Delhi government will announce a new borewell policy under which permissions will be given to domestic users with ease,” Verma said.

He said that the chief minister has directed that the entire process be made easy without the district magistrate’s no-objection certificate.

Better water management will be the aim of the government to fulfil the current drinking requirements of the city, Verma added.

Officially, Delhi has around 5,000 borewells, but authorities claim the actual number is much higher.

Meanwhile, Verma also said that the government is working on increasing the city’s overall sewage treatment capacity to 1,500 million gallons per day (MGD) in the next few years.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah interacts with Delhi L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu, on Friday

PTI

DELHI hosts first ‘Skill Connect 2026’ conclave

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Friday organised the first Industry–Academia Conclave under “Skill Connect 2026” at CM Shri School, Raj Niwas Marg, aimed at strengthening ties between education and industry while enhancing students’ employability skills.

Education Minister Ashish Sood attended the event as chief guest, where he visited student exhibition stalls and appreciated their innovation and confidence. The conclave brought together industry experts, academicians, policymakers, and training institutions to discuss skill development and workforce readiness.

Addressing the gathering, Sood emphasized the government’s focus on equipping youth with relevant skills for a changing economy. “Through the ‘Skill Connect 2026’ Conclave, the Delhi Government is committed to providing youth with modern and rel-



evant skills, enabling them to become self-reliant in a rapidly evolving economy and contribute actively to the nation’s development,” he said.

Highlighting the scale of the initiative, the minister noted that over 30,000 internship opportunities have been facilitated through more than 2,000 employers. He also launched the ‘Internship Gear for Students’ and ‘Internship Saathi’ booklets to streamline and strengthen internship programs.

Sood underlined the need to move beyond traditional education models.

Govt to launch citywide drive to map vulnerable children

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will roll out a citywide mapping exercise in April to identify vulnerable children, link them with welfare schemes and boost awareness about the child helpline number 1098.

The Department of Women and Child Development (WCD), in collaboration with non-profit organisations, will run a campaign across slum areas to sensitise residents about available support systems.

Official data shows that following the merger of the child helpline with 112 has led to a drop in direct registrations, as many callers now dial emergency numbers, resulting in gaps in reporting.

A recent meeting between the NGO and the department led to a multi-stakeholder consultation aimed at improving coordination between government agencies and civil society organisations, and strengthening efforts to make Delhi more child-friendly, he said.

These included child abuse (4,249), counselling support (1,951), missing children (1,984) and child-family issues (1,114).

Sanjay Gupta, director of

The Department of WCD, in collaboration with non-profit organisations, will run a campaign across slum areas

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A recent meeting between the NGO and the department led to a multi-stakeholder consultation aimed at improving coordination between government agencies and civil society organisations, and strengthening efforts to make Delhi more child-friendly, he said.

An official said the consultation was necessitated by emerging concerns and operational challenges in the child protection system, including a rise in

missing children, documentation barriers — particularly in Aadhaar enrolment — gaps in follow-up and reintegration after family reunification, and limited awareness at the community level about child protection services and reporting mechanisms.

The WCD department, along with Samagra Shiksha Delhi, NGOs and other stakeholders, is also working to identify out-of-school children and ensure their enrolment in schools.

As part of the initiative, 104 stakeholders, including officials from WCD, Child Helpline, Child Welfare Committees, the Juvenile Justice Board, and civil society groups, among others, are participating in the consultation process.

The engagement aims to improve coordination, address systemic gaps and develop a shared roadmap to strengthen child protection services across the city, Gupta said.

JAN VISHWAS BILL: Changes made to fines under DDA Act

NEW DELHI: The Central government has proposed changes for fines for flouting norms under the Delhi Development Act, 1957, which governs the functioning of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, was introduced by Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada in the Lok Sabha on Friday.

In Section 29 of the act, the word ‘penalties’ has been changed to ‘punishment’. With regard to the punishment for carrying out development in contravention of the Master Plan, the punishment has been reduced to ‘imprisonment’ from the earlier “rigorous imprisonment.”

However, in its sub-section under simple imprisonment, the fine has been increased to

Rs 50,000 from Rs 5,000.

Furthermore, in sub-section 2, the fine has been increased to Rs 2500 per day for every day during which such contravention continues after the order imposing penalty has been passed and confirmed for the first contravention.

The bills seeks to amend the punishment rules for any person who assaults any person authorised under Section 28 to enter into or upon any land or building, after such entry, they “shall be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to six months, or with fine which may extend to ten thousand rupees, or with both,” the bill states.

Currently the fine in this offence is Rs 1,000 which has been increased to Rs 10,000, the term of imprisonment has remained the same. AGENCIES

Blame game: 675 slums, 0 sewers

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A long-running environmental case before the National Green Tribunal (NGT) has exposed a glaring gap in Delhi’s sanitation system, with two key agencies, the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) and the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), shifting responsibility for laying sewer lines in slum clusters, leaving hundreds of settlements without basic infrastructure.

Submissions made before the tribunal show that both bodies have denied accountability, each claiming the task falls under the other’s jurisdiction. As a result, around 675 slum clusters across the Capital continue to function without sewer connectivity, with waste flowing into stormwater drains and open nallas.

In its affidavit, DUSIB clarified that its mandate is limited to constructing pavements,

CLOSER LOOK

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» As a result, around 675 slum clusters across the Capital continue to function without sewer connectivity, with waste flowing into stormwater drains and open nallas

» The matter is being heard by an NGT bench led by Justice Prakash Shrivastava, in a case originally filed over a decade ago by the Nizamuddin West Association

stormwater drains and public toilet complexes, and does not include laying sewer pipelines in Jhuggi Jhopri clusters. It stated that this responsibility lies with DJB. However, DJB, in its own filings, argued that it cannot establish sewage treatment systems in these areas without a prior sewer network, which, according to it, must be developed by DUSIB.

The matter is being heard by an NGT bench led by Justice Prakash Shrivastava, in

a case originally filed over a decade ago by the Nizamuddin West Association regarding untreated sewage entering the Yamuna through the Defence Colony drain and Barapullah.

Data submitted by DUSIB indicates that sewage from these clusters is largely discharged into drains, while waste from nearly 680 public toilet complexes is either connected to existing sewer lines or diverted to septic tanks. Household waste, however, often has

no proper disposal system.

The DJB informed the tribunal that 17 out of 43 identified drains have been tapped, while work on 22 more is underway. However, two major drains, carrying nearly 40 million litres of untreated sewage daily from areas such as Mehrauli, Chhatrapur and Saket, remain untreated due to pending environmental clearances.

Adding to the concerns, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has faced scrutiny over claims of securing the Defence Colony drain. Fresh submissions, backed by photographic evidence, suggest that several sections remain open and hazardous.

With multiple agencies locked in a jurisdictional dispute, the tribunal is set to review the matter again, as untreated sewage continues to flow into the Yamuna, underscoring persistent governance and coordination challenges.

NDMC mandates 4-stream waste segregation from Apr

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council will enforce mandatory four-stream segregation of waste at source from April 1, in line with the Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026, as part of its push towards a cleaner and more circular urban system, officials said on Friday.

Under the new framework, all waste generators will be required to segregate waste into four distinct categories — wet, dry, sanitary, and special care waste — before handing it over to authorised collectors, they said.

Defining “waste generator” broadly, the rules cover all individuals, households, offices and institutions, including railways and defence establishments.

In a post on X, the civic body explained that wet waste, including kitchen scraps, vegetable and fruit peels, and flowers, will be directed for composting or bio-methanation, while dry waste such

as plastic, paper, metal, glass, wood, and rubber will be sent to material recovery facilities.

Sanitary waste like diapers and sanitary products must be securely wrapped and stored separately, and hazardous “special care” waste such as paint cans, expired medicines, bulbs and thermometers will be handled by authorised waste pickers.

Further, bulk waste generators, including gated communities and institutions with an area exceeding 5,000 square metres, will be required to process wet waste on-site. The rules also prohibit mixing of biomedical waste with general solid waste.

The SWM Rules, 2026, also incorporate the “polluter pays” principle, enabling authorities to levy environmental compensation for violations such as non-segregation, unauthorised operations, false reporting, and improper waste handling practices. AGENCIES

AFTER FATAL JANUARY CRASH

DGCA sets guidelines for aircraft operators flying VIPs and VVIPs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI/ NEW DELHI: Aviation regulator DGCA on Friday issued guidelines for aircraft operators flying VIPs and VVIPs, including chief ministers and governors, and emphasised that the crew should not be subjected to any undue pressure for operating a flight that might impact safety.

The guidelines, applicable for non-scheduled aircraft and helicopter operators carrying VVIPs, also come against the backdrop of the fatal plane crash in January that killed Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar and four others. DGCA said the aircraft operator should ensure that the flight operations are in accordance with the Aircraft Rules and instructions/order/circular issued from time to time and flight crew are not subjected to undue pressure for undertaking a flight which may impact safety of operations. “Any last-minute changes to

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The guidelines, applicable for non-scheduled aircraft and helicopter operators carrying VVIPs, also come against the backdrop of the fatal plane crash in January that killed Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar and four others
- » ‘Any last-minute changes to the planned flight due to VIP requirements should be coordinated

through the organisation’s management only, and not directly with the crew’

- » Issuing the guidelines, DGCA also said an analysis of earlier accidents/incidents associated with aircraft operations to/from airstrips/temporary helipads and during election flying of VVIPs has often revealed violation of instructions and safety was jeopardised

the planned flight due to VIP requirements should be coordinated through the organisation’s management only, and not directly with the crew,” it said.

Issuing the guidelines, DGCA also said an analysis of earlier accidents/incidents associated with aircraft operations to/from airstrips/temporary

helipads and during election flying of VVIPs has often revealed violation of instructions and safety was jeopardised.

“It is essential that adequate measures are taken by all concerned to ensure the highest standards of safety for the operation of such flights,” the Directorate General of Civil Aviation

(DGCA) said.

With respect to election flying, the watchdog said each operator should nominate a responsible person for managing such flights, and the person would be accountable for ensuring compliance with all instructions issued by the authorities concerned. The person would have to follow the instructions issued by DGCA, AAI (Airports Authority of India), BCAS (Bureau of Civil Aviation Security) and the Election Commission. The person’s particulars should be submitted to the Flight Standards Directorate, DGCA, before commencement of election flying, as per the order. The Pilot In Command (PIC) of a non-scheduled aircraft flying VVIPs should have a total experience of at least 3,000 flying hours, and in the case of helicopters, it has to be 2,000 flying hours experience. “Election flying is a highly demanding exercise in terms of skill levels, professionalism

and tact,” the regulator said, and mentioned about various challenges in this regard, including long flying hours, a large number of take-offs and landings, hurriedly prepared helipads, frequent changes in itinerary and highly stressed security arrangements. According to the order, the operator’s accountable manager should inform the person being flown to respect the decisions taken by the flight crew, aircraft maintenance engineers and other professionals involved in flight planning and dispatch. The decisions taken by them regarding continuation, diversion or aborting of the flight should be respected, and the crew must remain free from any external pressure of undue influence, as per the order.

Among other requirements, the flight crew should ensure strict compliance with weather minima and proper weather briefing before commencement of flights as per existing regulations. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

UP: Eight killed, 18 injured in pickup-trailer collision

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

KANPUR: Eight people are killed and 18 others injured in a tragic road accident on the Kanpur–Prayagraj highway on Friday. The incident takes place near Dorma petrol pump in the Saini police station area when a speeding pickup vehicle loses control and crashes into a stationary trailer parked on the roadside.

The impact of the collision is severe, leaving the pickup completely mangled and triggering panic among passengers. Around 25 people, including women and children, are travelling in the vehicle at the time of the accident.

According to initial information, all the victims are residents of Barokhar village in the Malwan area of Fatehpur district. They are returning from Prayagraj after performing a child’s head-shaving ritual on the occasion of Ram Navami. The group had also taken a holy dip at the Sangam before beginning their journey back home.

The accident occurs at around 3:45 pm, leading to chaos at the scene. Passersby and local residents rush to



Medical workers and security officials at the site, on Friday PTI

help the injured and inform the police. Police and health department teams reach the spot soon after receiving information.

Four ambulances are deployed to shift the injured to nearby hospitals. Seven people die while being taken for treatment, while one more succumbs later, taking the

death toll to eight. The injured are currently undergoing treatment.

The accident leads to a temporary traffic jam on the highway. Authorities later clear the road with the help of a crane to remove the damaged vehicle and restore traffic movement.

Police have launched an investigation into the incident.

From Page 1

West Asia conflict

smooth functioning of supply chains and take strict action against hoarding and profiteering. He called for activation of control rooms at state and district levels and stressed administrative alertness to prevent disruptions.

He also highlighted the need for advance planning in the agriculture sector, particularly in monitoring fertiliser storage and distribution ahead of the Kharif season to avoid any inconvenience to farmers.

The Prime Minister cautioned against the spread of misinformation and rumours, underlining the importance of timely dissemination of accurate information to prevent panic. He also advised vigilance against online fraud and fake agents.

This is the first time that the prime minister held such a meeting with the chief ministers on the West Asia conflict which started on February 28 with the attack by the US-Israel on Iran. Iran also retaliated by firing on its Gulf neighbours and Israel.

Those chief ministers who attended the meeting included N Chandra Babu Naidu (Andhra Pradesh), Yogi Adityanath (Uttar Pradesh), Revanth Reddy (Telangana), Bhagwant Mann (Punjab), Bhupendra Patel (Gujarat), Omar Abdullah (Jammu and Kashmir), Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu (Himachal Pradesh), Pema Khandu (Arunachal Pradesh) among others.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit Shah were also present in the meeting.

“The prime minister interacted with the chief ministers through video conferencing on the West Asia conflict and reviewed preparedness and plans of the states. The meeting focused on ensuring synergy of efforts in the spirit of Team India,” a source said.

The chief ministers of election-bound states were not part of this meeting due to the Model Code of Conduct (MCC).

The Cabinet Secretariat is going to hold a separate meeting with the chief secretaries of poll-bound Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Assam, Kerala and the Union Territory of Puducherry.

On March 25, the government held an all-party meeting to brief the leaders of the political parties about the West Asia situation, where a detailed presentation was given about the steps taken by the government to deal with the situation.

The government also ruled out any possibility of imposing a lock down as India has enough petrol, diesel and LPG stocks to last at least two months with normal delivery cycles.

“There is no situation like lockdown. It is not even under consideration,” Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said at a media briefing on the situation arising out of war in West Asia.

She said panic buying and long queues at petrol pumps and LPG

distributors in parts have been triggered by misinformation and rumours.

“There is no crisis or shortage,” she said. “We have a sufficient amount of crude oil (raw material to make fuels like petrol and diesel). Our stocks of petrol and diesel are sufficient, and LPG supplies have been ensured.”

All petrol pumps across the country are adequately stocked and operating normally, with no rationing of petrol or diesel.

Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, in a post on X, said while the global situation remains in flux, “all necessary steps are being taken to ensure uninterrupted availability of fuel, energy, and other critical supplies for our citizens.”

“Rumours of a lockdown in India are completely false. Let me state this clearly, there is no such proposal under consideration by the Government of India.”

India, he said, has consistently demonstrated resilience in the face of global uncertainties, and the government will continue to act in a timely, proactive, and coordinated manner.

“In such times, it is important that we remain calm, responsible, and united. Attempts to spread rumours and create panic in such a situation are irresponsible and harmful,” he added.

Attacks on Iran

under construction as part of China’s “Belt and Road” initiative, sustained “material damage” in attacks. It appeared to be one of the first times a Chinese-affiliated project in the Gulf Arab states has come under assault in the war. China has continued to purchase Iranian crude.

US stocks fell on opening Friday, in a fifth straight losing week — Wall Street’s longest such streak in nearly four years. The S&P 500 dropped 0.4 per cent in early trading Friday. The Dow lost 0.6 per cent, and the Nasdaq fell 0.6 per cent, breaking the week’s pattern of flip-flopping gains and losses as hopes for an end to the war vacillated.

Asian shares also fell Friday over growing doubts about the chances of de-escalation. Oil prices rose again, the Brent crude, the international standard, at USD 107 a barrel in morning trading, up more than 45 per cent since Israel and the US attacked Iran on February 28 to start the war.

Iran’s stranglehold on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has increased concerns of a global energy crisis, and appears part of a strategy to get the US to back down by roiling the world economy.

Trump envoy Steve Witkoff said Washington delivered a 15-point “action list” to Iran for a possible ceasefire, using Pakistan as an intermediary. It proposes restricting Iran’s nuclear programme and reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran rejected the US offer and presented its own five-point proposal that included reparations and recognition of its sovereignty over the vital strait.

Diplomats from several countries have tried to organise a direct meeting between US and Iran envoys, possibly in Pakistan.

Egypt’s Foreign Ministry said

in a statement Friday that Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty spoke with his Turkish and Pakistani counterparts by phone as part of “intensive efforts” to organise the talks.

Abdelatty said they hoped for “gradual de-escalation efforts that would ultimately lead to the end of the war.”

Meanwhile, US ships drew closer to the region carrying some 2,500 Marines, and at least 1,000 paratroopers from the 82nd Airborne — trained to land in hostile territory to secure key positions and airfields — have been ordered to the Middle East.

The UN’s International Organization for Migration said Friday that 82,000 civilian buildings in Iran, including hospitals and the homes of 180,000 people, are damaged.

Eighteen people have died in Israel, while 49 Israeli soldiers have been killed in Lebanon.

Authorities said more than 1,100 people have died in Lebanon and over 1,900 people have been killed in Iran.

At least 13 American troops have been killed and four people in the occupied West Bank and 20 in Gulf Arab states have also died.

At G7 meet, Jaishankar

supplies and food security” in a session focused on global governance reforms. He also pointed to the need for urgent changes, including reform of the UN Security Council, improved efficiency in peacekeeping operations and stronger humanitarian supply chains.

In a separate discussion, the minister underlined the importance of building resilient trade corridors and supply chains amid uncertainties triggered by the West Asia conflict. He referred to the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor and noted that India’s free trade agreements with the European Free Trade Association, the United Kingdom and the European Union have enhanced its potential.

Jaishankar also stressed the importance of safeguarding freedom of navigation for global economic security and flagged concerns around narco-terror linkages. On critical minerals, he welcomed ongoing efforts to expand cooperation across the value chain.

On the sidelines of the meeting, Jaishankar held a series of bilateral engagements. His talks with Marco Rubio were described as “useful” and marked their first meeting since the outbreak of the West Asia conflict on February 28. He also met Saudi Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan, German Foreign Minister Johann Wadepuhl and Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha, with the regional crisis featuring prominently in discussions.

Additional meetings were held with Canadian Foreign Minister Anita Anand, South Korea’s Cho Hyun, Italy’s Antonio Tajani, Japan’s Toshimitsu Motegi and Brazil’s Mauro Vieira.

In a bilateral meeting with French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot, both sides agreed to maintain close coordination to help ensure security in the Strait of Hormuz, according to the French foreign ministry.

The ministry noted that India’s participation reflects its growing role, particularly as it holds the BRICS presidency. It also confirmed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi will attend the G7 summit in Evian from June 15 to 17.

The G7 comprises Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the United Kingdom and the United States, along with the European Union, and serves as a key platform for coordinating responses to global economic and geopolitical challenges.

Nepal gets

The demonstrations, triggered by allegations of corruption, nepotism and a controversial social media ban, escalated into unrest and ultimately forced a political reset. Following the government’s fall, former chief justice Sushila Karki was appointed interim prime minister on the recommendation of protest leaders.

Shah, who had earlier declined to head the interim administration, chose instead to contest elections for a full mandate. His victory was decisive, including a major win in the Jhapa-5 constituency, a long-standing stronghold of Oli’s party. The election results significantly weakened traditional political forces, with the Nepali Congress reduced to 38 seats, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) to 25, and the Nepali Communist Party securing only 17 seats.

In her message following the swearing-in ceremony, Karki congratulated Shah and expressed optimism about the transition. “I feel all the more elated that a 35-year-old young man is my successor. I extend my best wishes to him. I wish him success in pushing forward the people’s mandate with vigour and rigour,” she said.

Shah’s appointment also carries regional significance as he becomes the first person from the Madhes region to hold the country’s top executive office. His leadership is seen as a departure from traditional political elites, reflecting the growing influence of younger voters and reform-driven agendas.

International reactions followed swiftly. Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated Shah and highlighted the importance of bilateral ties. “Your appointment reflects the trust reposed in your leadership by the people of Nepal. I look forward to working closely with you to take India-Nepal friendship and cooperation to even greater heights for the mutual benefit of our two peoples,” Modi said in a message on X. India and Nepal share longstanding cultural and economic ties, often described as a “Roti Beti” relationship, with Nepal relying heavily on India for trade and access to sea routes.

Pakistan’s Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif also extended congratulations, while China signalled its readiness to deepen cooperation with Nepal’s new government. Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian said Beijing is prepared to strengthen traditional friendship and practical collaboration.

Alongside Shah, a new council of ministers was sworn in. Swarnim Wagle assumed charge as Finance Minister, Shisir Khanal took over Foreign Affairs, and Sudan Gurung was appointed Home Minister. Shah himself will oversee the Defence Ministry as well as the Industry, Commerce and Supplies Ministry.

Other key appointments include Biraj Bhakta Shrestha as Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, Bikram Timilsina as Minister for Communications and Information Technology, and Pratibha Rawal as Minister of Federal Affairs and General Administration. Ganesh Paudel will head Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, while Sunil Lamsal will manage Physical Infrastructure and Transport.

Further, Gita Chaudhary was sworn in as Agriculture and Livestock Development Minister, Sasmit Pokharel as Education, Science and Technology Minister, Nisha Mehata as Health and Population Minister, Sita Badi as Minister of Women, Children and Senior Citizens, and Sobita Gautam as Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs.

Shah’s election sets him apart from earlier young leaders in Nepal’s history who were appointed rather than elected. For instance, Tulsi Giri, who took office in 1963 at around 37 years of age, was nominated by the monarchy rather than chosen through a democratic mandate.

With a strong parliamentary majority and broad public backing, Shah now faces the challenge of delivering on promises that emerged from a movement demanding accountability and systemic change.

Tragedy at Zojila Pass:

ensure all possible support reaches the affected families.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah also expressed grief over the incident, offering condolences to the families of the deceased and wishing a speedy recovery to the injured. Both leaders described the loss of lives as deeply distressing, as teams continued operations in the challenging terrain along the strategic highway.

HC rejects plea

Azure Global, claiming over Rs 2,000 crore in bribes were paid to officials of DISCOMs in Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Jammu and Kashmir to secure contracts at inflated tariffs.

The plea cited “bribe notes” and electronic records allegedly maintained by Adani Green executive director Sagar Adani and later seized by the FBI. It argued that certified US court documents constituted reliable evidence requiring action.

Maru said complaints sent to the CBI on October 21 and 29, 2025 went unanswered. The court, however, declined to intervene.

Earlier in the day, the bench also dismissed another petition by Maru seeking a CBI probe against Reliance Industries over alleged gas extraction from ONGC fields.

Allahabad HC

with the man of her own free will. Rejecting the argument that the man’s marital status could make the relationship a criminal act, the bench stated, “There is no offence where a married man is staying with an adult woman in a live-in relationship with her consent.”

The judges drew a clear distinction between societal values and legal principles, observing that “morality and law have to be kept apart” and that courts cannot be guided by social opinion when no offence is made out under the law.

The couple told the court that the woman’s family opposed the relationship and had issued death threats, raising concerns about a possible honour killing. The woman had earlier submitted a complaint to the Shahjahanpur Superintendent of Police, but the court noted that no action appeared to have been taken.

Taking serious note of the alleged inaction, the bench underlined that it is the duty of the police to protect consenting adults. It referred to the Supreme Court’s 2018 ruling in Shakti Vahini v. Union of India, which places specific obligations on authorities to prevent honour-based violence.

The High Court directed that no coercive action be taken against the petitioners until further orders and restrained the woman’s family members from interfering with their lives. It also barred them from entering the couple’s residence or contacting them directly or indirectly. The local police chief was made personally responsible for ensuring the couple’s safety.

The court granted two weeks for the filing of a counter affidavit and scheduled the next hearing for April 8. In a related development, the High Court had in December last year ordered protection for 12 live-in couples who reported threats from their families. In that order, the court reiterated that the right to life and personal liberty applies regardless of marital status, stating that adults in such relationships are entitled to state protection. The latest ruling reinforces the legal position that consensual relationships between adults, even involving a married individual, do not attract criminal liability, and that safeguarding such individuals remains a constitutional obligation.

Tehsildar, who

probe into the transactions. Officials said relatives and acquaintances of the accused were falsely listed as beneficiaries, allowing funds meant for genuine victims to be siphoned off.

Police have so far named more than 100 individuals as accused in the case, including Tomar and several revenue officials. Authorities suspect collusion between tehsil staff and intermediaries in executing the scheme. Tomar had made multiple attempts to avoid arrest. Her anticipatory bail plea was rejected by the Gwalior bench of the High Court, and a subsequent Special Leave Petition filed before the Supreme Court was dismissed on March 17, 2026.

Following the court’s decision, police arrested her from her residence in Gwalior. She had been

removed from her post as Vijaypur tehsildar a day prior to her arrest.

Sheopur Superintendent of Police Sudhir Kumar Agrawal confirmed the development, stating that “the investigation is ongoing and the involvement of more officials and staff is likely to emerge.”

The case has been registered under several sections of the IPC, including cheating, forgery, criminal breach of trust and conspiracy, along with provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act.

DAC clears Rs 2.38 lakh cr

The council also approved the acquisition of remotely piloted strike aircraft, which will support offensive counter air and coordinated air operations, alongside intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance roles. Additionally, the overhaul of Su-30 aero engines and associated aggregates was cleared to extend the service life of the fighter fleet and maintain operational readiness.

For the Indian Army, the DAC approved a suite of systems aimed at improving battlefield awareness, firepower and communication. These include the Air Defence Tracked System, which will provide real-time control and reporting of air defence operations, and High Capacity Radio Relay systems designed to ensure reliable and secure communications.

The approvals also cover Armoured Piercing Tank Ammunition to enhance anti-tank lethality, and the Runway Independent Aerial Surveillance System, which will enable flexible deployment of surveillance assets without reliance on conventional airstrips.

A key artillery upgrade comes in the form of the Dhanush gun system, an indigenously developed 155mm x 45-calibre towed artillery gun. Based on the FH-155 Bofors platform, the system incorporates digitised controls, improved targeting and navigation, and offers an effective firing range of up to 38 kilometres under operational conditions. Officials said its induction will enable the Army to engage targets at longer ranges with improved accuracy across diverse terrains.

The Indian Coast Guard will also benefit from the approvals, with the DAC granting AoN for Heavy Duty Air Cushion Vehicles. These platforms are intended for high-speed coastal patrolling, reconnaissance, search and rescue operations, and logistical support, including the transport of personnel and supplies in challenging maritime environments.

The defence ministry said that in the financial year 2025 to 26, the DAC has so far accorded AoN for 55 proposals amounting to Rs 6.73 lakh crore. In addition, capital procurement contracts have been signed for 503 proposals worth Rs 2.28 lakh crore during the current fiscal year.

According to the ministry, both the total value of approvals and the number of contracts signed represent the highest levels recorded in any financial year to date. Officials said the latest round of clearances reflects continued momentum in defence modernisation, with a focus on capability enhancement, indigenisation and readiness across all three services.

Jan Vishwas Bill's 2nd edition introduced in LS



Uttar Pradesh Taking Off to New Heights









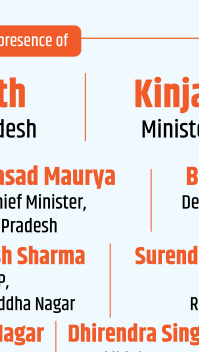

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by

Narendra Modi

Prime Minister







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Governor, Uttar Pradesh

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Minister, Civil Aviation, Government of India

Pankaj Chaudhary

Minister of State, Finance,
Government of India

Brajesh Singh

Minister of State, Public Works
Department, Uttar Pradesh

Keshav Prasad Maurya

Deputy Chief Minister,
Uttar Pradesh

Dr. Mahesh Sharma

MP,
Gautam Buddha Nagar

Brajesh Pathak

Deputy Chief Minister,
Uttar Pradesh

Surendra Singh Nagar

Member,
Rajya Sabha

Amit Chaudhary

Chairman, District Panchayat, Gautam Buddha Nagar

Lakshmi Raj Singh

MLA, Sikandrabad

Pankaj Singh

MLA, Noida

Shrikant Sharma

MLA, Mathura

Tejpal Singh Nagar

MLA, Dadri

Minakshi Singh

MLA, Khurja

Dhirendra Singh

MLA, Jewar

Jaiveer Singh

MLA, Barauli

Sanjay Kumar Sharma

MLA, Anupshahr

Narendra Singh Bhati

MLC

Surender Diler

MLA, Khair

Shrichand Sharma

MLC

and other dignitaries

Date: 28th March, 2026 | Time: 11:30 AM | Venue: Jewar, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh

Vikas ki Gati Apaar-Double Engine Sarkar





EDITORIAL

RELIEF
WITHOUT
REDUCTION

The government's decision to cut excise duty on petrol and diesel has been presented as a timely intervention to shield consumers from rising global oil prices. On paper, the move appears decisive—a Rs 10 per litre reduction in Special Additional Excise Duty (SAED) suggests an attempt to ease inflationary pressures and offer relief to households. Yet, at the petrol pump, where such relief is expected to be felt most immediately, there has been no visible change. Prices remain unchanged, and for consumers already navigating high living costs, the announcement rings hollow. What is being framed as consumer relief is, in reality, something more complex—and far less direct.

At its core, the duty cut represents not a reduction in the burden, but a redistribution of it. Oil marketing companies (OMCs), which have been absorbing steep losses due to elevated crude prices, are the primary beneficiaries of this adjustment. Estimates suggest under-recoveries of around Rs 24 per litre on petrol and Rs 30 per litre on diesel—figures that make it clear why companies have been reluctant to pass on any gains immediately. By lowering excise duty, the government is effectively stepping in to share part of this burden, preventing a sharp increase in retail prices rather than enabling a decrease. In that sense, the move is defensive, not transformative. It seeks to stabilise the system, not necessarily to lighten the load on consumers.

This distinction matters because it reshapes how the policy should be understood. For households, the absence of a price cut translates into no immediate savings, no reduction in transport costs, and no easing of inflationary pressures that ripple across goods and services. The benefit, if any, is indirect—it lies in the avoidance of a potential price hike rather than in any tangible decrease. That may be economically prudent in the short term, but politically and perceptually, it creates a gap between expectation and experience. When relief is announced but not felt, credibility risks erosion.

The fiscal implications of the move further complicate the picture. A duty cut of this scale comes at a high cost to government revenues, with estimates pointing to a potential annual loss of around Rs 1.5 lakh crore. To offset this, the Centre has imposed export duties on diesel and aviation turbine fuel, effectively shifting the tax burden from domestic consumption to overseas sales. While this balancing act may provide a temporary fiscal cushion, it raises deeper questions about sustainability. If global crude prices remain elevated, the government may find itself caught between the competing pressures of maintaining revenue, supporting OMCs, and containing inflation—all without a clear long-term solution.

Underlying all of this is the fundamental vulnerability of India's energy architecture. As a country that imports the bulk of its crude oil, India remains exposed to global volatility—whether driven by geopolitical tensions, supply disruptions, or shifts in demand. The current crisis is a reminder that domestic policy tools, such as tax adjustments, can only do so much in the face of external shocks. Private fuel retailers have already begun passing on higher costs, signalling the limits of price control in a market that is, at least in part, deregulated. State-run companies may hold the line for now, but such restraint cannot be sustained indefinitely without financial consequences.

In practical terms, then, the excise duty cut offers only a limited and largely invisible form of relief. It delays the pain rather than removes it, cushions companies rather than consumers, and shifts financial pressure onto government accounts rather than eliminating it. For a policy framed as consumer protection, this is a narrow outcome. The real test will come in the weeks ahead: if global crude prices remain high, the space for maintaining current retail prices will shrink, forcing either further fiscal intervention or an eventual pass-through to consumers.

What this episode ultimately highlights is the need for a more structural approach to energy policy. Short-term fixes, while necessary, cannot substitute for long-term resilience. Diversifying energy sources, accelerating the transition to renewables, and building strategic buffers are no longer optional—they are essential. Until then, India's fuel pricing will continue to be shaped less by domestic decisions and more by global forces beyond its control. For now, the government's move may have bought time. But time, in itself, is not relief. And unless that time is used to address the deeper vulnerabilities in the system, the promise of protection at the pump will remain just that—a promise, rather than a reality.

GREEN
IMPERATIVE



SHISHIR PRIYADARSHI
& SANDRA KURIAN

S PRIYADARSHI IS
THE PRESIDENT,
AND S KURIAN
IS A RESEARCH
ASSOCIATE, BOTH
AT CHINTAN
RESEARCH
FOUNDATION

India is
building at an
unprecedented
pace, but
outdated
infrastructure
models risk
locking in
inefficiency
and vulnerability

The Infrastructure Reckoning

India's infrastructure push must shift from scale to sustainability, embedding resilience, efficiency and climate intelligence to secure long-term economic stability and competitiveness

India is building its infrastructure at a speed and scale that few countries have ever experienced. Highways, industrial corridors, smart cities, and energy systems are transforming the country's economic landscape. But scale, by itself, is no longer the right metric of success. The real question is not how much India builds, but what it builds, and whether it is fit for the future.

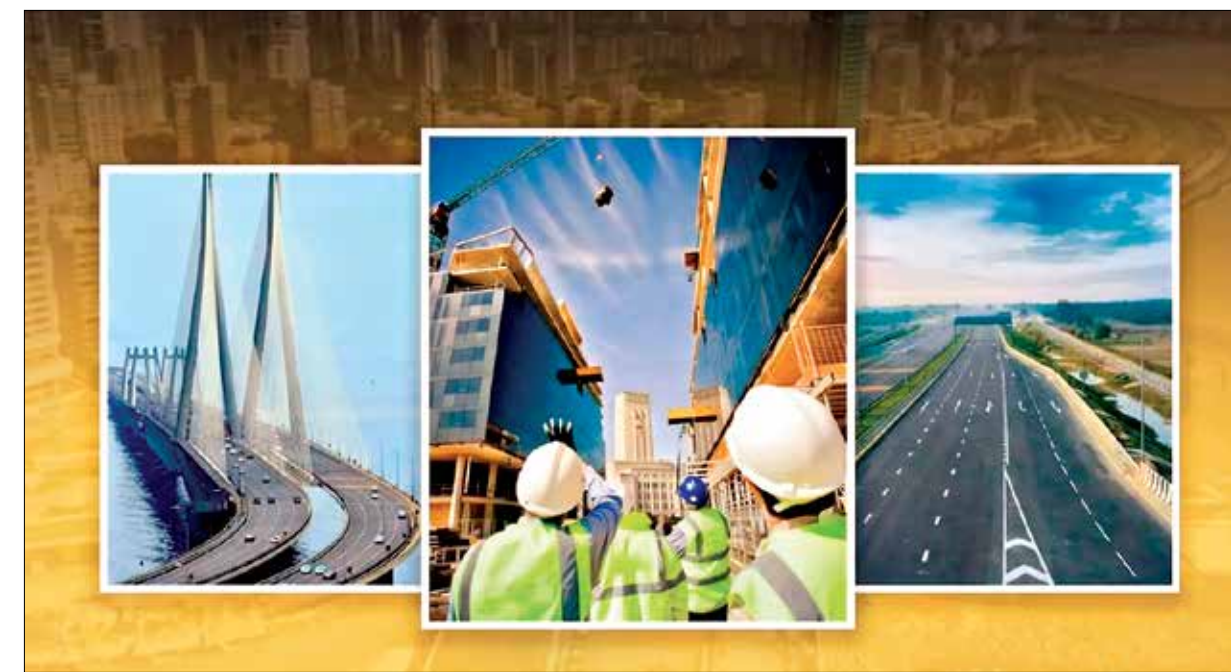
For decades, infrastructure has been approached as a quantity-driven exercise. Today, that approach is increasingly misaligned with reality. Climate extremes – heatwaves, floods, erratic rainfall – are already testing the limits of existing systems. Infrastructure built for yesterday's conditions is struggling to cope with today's disruptions. In this context, the idea of "business as usual" is not just outdated; it is risky.

This is where the idea of a green reset becomes critical. Green infrastructure is not a niche category or a parallel agenda. It is about embedding sustainability, resilience, and efficiency into the very definition of infrastructure. The shift is fundamental: infrastructure can no longer be climate-neutral. It must be climate-intelligent by design. The infrastructure choices India makes today will determine not just the pace of growth, but the stability and resilience of that growth over the next century.

The False Dichotomy
One of the most persistent misconceptions in infrastructure debates is that green solutions are more expensive. But this perception rests on a flawed understanding of cost. Traditional, or "brown" infrastructure, appears cheaper because it excludes a range of hidden liabilities: inefficient energy use, high maintenance costs, vulnerability to climate shocks, and the eventual need for retrofitting or rebuilding. These costs are not eliminated; they are simply deferred.

Green infrastructure, by contrast, demands greater attention – and sometimes investment – upfront, but delivers long-term savings through efficiency, durability, and resilience. The real choice, therefore, is not between green and non-green infrastructure. It is between paying once for resilience or paying repeatedly for failure.

As climate risks intensify, these hidden costs will become increasingly visible in the form



India's infrastructure story must shift from building more to building smarter, or risk locking in inefficiency for decades

of fiscal stress, disrupted supply chains, and lost productivity. Seen through this lens, green infrastructure is not an environmental preference; it is a form of economic risk management. The cost of building resilient systems is upfront. The cost of not building them is permanent.

Competing Green
Green infrastructure is no longer just a domestic development issue; it is becoming central to global economic competitiveness. Trade and investment patterns are shifting. Carbon footprints, sustainability standards, and access to green finance increasingly influence supply chains. Regulatory frameworks are evolving to favour low-carbon production systems. In a carbon-conscious world, infrastructure will quietly determine who competes and who falls behind.

Energy-efficient industrial zones, low-carbon logistics networks, and sustainable urban ecosystems directly shape production costs, export competitiveness, and investment attractiveness. Countries that fail to align their infrastructure with these evolving standards risk facing implicit trade barriers and higher costs of capital. Those who move early stand to gain. For India, this presents a strategic opportunity.

Smart, green infrastructure can significantly reduce operational costs, improve efficiency, and enhance reliability. More importantly, it can position India as a preferred destination

in a world where sustainability is becoming a key determinant of economic engagement. Green infrastructure, therefore, is no longer about compliance; it is about positioning effectively in a changing global economy.

Designing Green
Delivering on a green infrastructure agenda requires a shift not just in intent, but in design. Too often, sustainability is treated as a compliance requirement – something to be addressed after core decisions have been made. This approach is both inefficient and costly. Sustainability cannot be retrofitted at scale; it must be embedded at the design stage.

Technology offers powerful tools to enable this shift – data is becoming as critical to infrastructure as concrete and steel. Digital solutions such as Building Information Modelling (BIM), IoT-enabled systems, and real-time analytics allow infrastructure to be simulated, stress-tested, and optimised before it is physically built. Increasingly, infrastructure will be constructed twice – first digitally, then on the ground.

But green design goes beyond technology. It requires rethinking what qualifies as infrastructure. Natural systems – wetlands, forests, and coastal ecosystems – often provide more resilient and cost-effective protection than engineered solutions alone. Integrating these into planning is not an environmental compromise; it is a smarter engineering choice. Equally critical is the need to

place water at the centre of infrastructure thinking. Groundwater depletion, urban flooding, and rainfall variability are emerging as systemic risks to India's growth. Yet, water systems remain fragmented and underinvested. Treating water management, from rainwater harvesting to watershed restoration, as core infrastructure is essential to building long-term resilience.

Finally, green infrastructure must be inclusive. Climate risks disproportionately affect vulnerable populations, and poorly designed systems can deepen inequalities. True resilience is not just technical; it is social.

From Transition to Transformation

If the case for green infrastructure is so compelling, why does progress remain uneven? The answer lies in two structural constraints: capability and capital.

On the capability side, India faces a significant skills gap. The infrastructure workforce must now integrate climate awareness, digital tools, and sustainability principles into planning and execution. This requires a fundamental shift in education and training – through updated curricula, modular certification programmes, and wider access to specialised skills beyond major urban centres.

On the capital side, financing models must evolve. While green infrastructure delivers long-term value, upfront costs can be a barrier. Innovative approaches such

as performance-based contracting, energy-as-a-service, and pay-as-you-save models can help align investments with realised benefits and reduce initial financial burdens.

Ultimately, green infrastructure will scale only when it becomes both technically viable and commercially attractive. But beyond these constraints lies a larger opportunity. India is not merely a participant in the global green transition; it has the potential to shape it. Unlike many developed economies, India is still building much of its infrastructure. This creates a rare opportunity to embed sustainability, resilience, and efficiency from the outset. If India succeeds, it will do more than transform its own economy. It will create scalable, cost-effective models for other emerging economies facing similar challenges. In doing so, India will not just build infrastructure. It will define a new development paradigm – one that aligns growth with sustainability and resilience.

The infrastructure India builds today will determine not just the economy it creates, but the risks it carries and the resilience it secures for generations to come. The case for a green reset is no longer environmental; it is economic, strategic, and unavoidable. And the question is no longer whether India can afford a green reset. It is whether it can afford to delay it.

Views expressed are personal

AT VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER
IS AN AUTHOR
AND MEDIA
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The effects of
war are felt far
and wide, and
yet the decisions
that precede
these actions
have little to no
parliamentary
approval or
global support

Whose war is it anyway?

Global wars are closer to home than ever before, with their aftermath causing shortages and uncertainty on Indian shores

Where unnecessary, uncalled-for wars go, the current one tops the list. This is what fragile egos and hollow men achieve – bloodshed, tension, shortage. The US-Israel versus Iran war is having a cascading effect on us all. When friends and family get stranded abroad, or gas supplies vanish at home, that war which felt hundreds of kilometres away seems to be at our doorstep. As the world was still reeling from the after-effects of Covid-19, and just about managing to resuscitate itself, human viruses have struck with alacrity. What would you call this world but a political order that we have elected? Across nations, such megalomaniacs have been democratically elected, who relish in strife, whose adrenaline rush stems from destroying world economies. Stock markets crash, lakhs may go hungry, but the glib rhetoric carries on. And remember, we the people have elected these part-buffoons and full-time evil warmongers.

There are things that we must fight against – climate change, poverty, gender imbalance, violence against women and children. There are perversions that must be fought and people protected. If we want disruptions, artificial intelligence (AI) is providing a ready one. Mother Earth is crying out for intervention;



So far, the war, which none of us signed up for, has pushed up energy and crude prices and halted or skyrocketed air travel

our air and water scream for rejuvenation. And yet, these men, these small men in their ivory towers, revel in triggering war-related exigencies. And then they go after a nation that has probably been preparing for such a day for the last few decades. US President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu have underestimated the doggedness of the Iranian regime. It's most pertinent to also note that the aggression of two leaders is negatively impacting over a dozen nations directly and indirectly, while putting

at least nine nations in harm's way of facing military attacks. The destabilisation of an entire region is on the shoulders of these men who have given two hoots about anyone except themselves. In one sweeping gesture, their actions blocked 20-25 per cent of the world's seaborne crude supply that passes through the Strait of Hormuz, affecting primarily Asian importers such as India, China, Japan, and South Korea.

Herein is a curious phenomenon. The effects of war are felt far and wide, and yet the decisions that precede these

actions have little to no parliamentary approval or global support. So while you can feel the repercussions of another nation's actions, you have no influence to stop them and scant power to protect your own. Immaturity, foolhardiness, selfishness, racism, or fear – whatever prompted Trump and Netanyahu to attack Iran has faced mild, toothless criticism from world leaders. While some have declined extending support to Trump when he asked for help to secure the Strait of Hormuz, several nations, including India, have

tactfully played it safe. The hard reality is that dialogue and compromise seem antiquated ideas. It's akin to two school bullies unleashing chaos in the school ground, but there are no strong teachers or parents, and the other kids prefer not to get embroiled either.

So far, the war, which none of us signed up for, has pushed up energy and crude prices and halted or skyrocketed air travel. Businesses are cautious, spends are meagre, shutdowns are increasing. In India, petrol and diesel prices are increasing more and more every day, commercial gas is being sold in black markets, while domestic LPG has an uncertain delivery date. The restaurant and food sector is struggling with establishments shutting down in the wake of the commercial gas shortage. Reports suggest that over 170 tile factories in Morbi, Gujarat, have stopped operations, while over 15,000 MSMEs are already sputtering due to gas and fuel shortage. Steel and cement industries are facing losses, as are the agriculture, logistics, and gems and jewellery industries. Supply chains are jittery, job loss is not far behind, and perhaps worryingly, neither is food shortage. And all of this over an unsolicited skirmish that we didn't even start. I suppose this is indeed kalyug (the age of darkness).

Views expressed are personal

FAULTLINES



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT, AND A FORMER NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR IN MAURITIUS

Allowing Pakistan to woo the US for any mediation on the Iran conflict could perhaps be an error of judgment, leading to serious implications, which only time will tell

Playing Both Sides, Losing Both

Pakistan's attempt to position itself as a mediator in the Iran conflict reveals contradictions, internal tensions, and a risky overestimation of its strategic relevance

Pakistan, almost a non-descript nation in geopolitics, is trying to come to the limelight by attempting to engage itself in several activities to be seen as a relevant country “resolving” the ongoing military conflict in Iran. However, it seems to be contradicting its position by expressing conflicting views on the Iran-Israel-US military quagmire, as evident in the recent statement of Asim Munir, telling Shia clerics in Pakistan that those who “love Iran so much” should go there. Munir’s outburst, perhaps tactless, was at the GHQ, which shows his arrogance and disrespect for Iran and the Shia clergy.

Reacting to this, the clerics said that Munir’s remarks appeared to blame the protests across Pakistan, triggered after the US and Israel killed Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, on the Shia community. Coincidentally, the army chief’s remarks were made on the same day Pakistan joined a bloc of Arab and Islamic countries in condemning Iran’s retaliatory strikes across the Gulf—a move that underscored the country’s shifting regional posture. Shia leaders present at the gathering said publicly after the meeting that Munir linked the unrest in Gilgit-Baltistan directly to the Shia leadership’s influence and held all members of the community collectively responsible for violence carried out by some. Leaders of the community found the framing both offensive and far removed from historical realism.

Subsequently, Shifa Najafi, a prominent Shia leader, provided a complete account of the meeting, saying that there are Shias in the Pakistan Army as well. The country was formed by Jinnah, who was a Shia himself. The military’s official account clarified that the gathering struck a different note, saying Munir had urged religious leaders to promote national unity and cautioned against sectarian divisions and external interference. Pakistan is second only to Iran in being home to the Shia community. Though a minority, the community is estimated to make up about 15 per cent of the country’s population. The unrest that Munir pointed out began in March, when demonstrations erupted across Pakistan following Khamenei’s death.

Significantly, the timing of Munir’s remarks sits within a broader shift in



Pakistan's recent actions reveal a deep contradiction in its foreign policy—publicly condemning Iran while simultaneously offering mediation

Pakistan’s regional calculus. Islamabad has long tried to balance its relations between Iran and the Gulf states, but has, in recent months, moved perceptibly closer to Saudi Arabia and its allies. The paradigm shift has not been without internal contradictions. Even as Pakistan joined the March 19 condemnation of Iran, Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar separately described the attacks on Iran as “unwarranted” and called for an immediate return to negotiations. We can, therefore, see an internal contradiction.

On the other hand, Asim Munir called (March 22) US President Donald Trump to discuss the Iran crisis and offered mediation, which was carried in the Financial Times, London. Pakistan is trying to position itself as a potential intermediary in the escalating tensions between the United States, Israel, and Iran, offering to host talks amid apprehensions about a wider regional

conflict. Earlier, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif separately spoke with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian. It is worth recalling that, over the past few months, US President Donald Trump has publicly referred to Munir as his favourite Field Marshal. Pakistani officials have even proposed Islamabad as a neutral venue for potential talks between US and Iranian representatives, indicating the country as a “discreet and credible” diplomatic bridge.

Meanwhile, in a separate development, the United States’s Director of National Intelligence (DNI), Tulsi Gabbard, has placed Pakistan alongside Russia, China, North Korea, and Iran as a country whose advancing missile capability could eventually put US territory within reach. Presenting (March 18) the 2026 Annual Threat Assessment (ATA) before the Senate Intelligence Committee, she said that five countries were “researching and developing an

array of novel, advanced or traditional missile delivery systems with nuclear and conventional payloads that put our homeland within range.” On Pakistan specifically, Gabbard averred that Pakistan’s long-range ballistic missile development could potentially include ICBMs with a range capable of striking the homeland. The written assessment went further, placing Pakistan across multiple threat categories. On missiles, the ATA stated that Pakistan “continues to develop increasingly sophisticated missile technology that provides its military the means to develop missile systems with the capability to strike targets beyond South Asia.”

Very significantly for India, the ATA referenced last year’s Pahalgam attack in Kashmir as an example of how violence by armed groups can spark crises, while claiming that President Trump’s intervention de-escalated the most recent nuclear tensions. Gabbard’s remarks

were framed around the future potential of Pakistan’s missile programme rather than its existing capability. But even from that futuristic prism, experts question the logic of the US intelligence assessment. Pakistan’s longest-range operational missile, the Shaheen-III, has an estimated range of roughly 2,750 km, sufficient to cover all of India.

Here, it is pertinent to mention that in January last year, senior US officials, speaking incognito at a briefing for non-governmental experts cited by the Arms Control Association, assessed that Pakistan’s ability to field long-range ballistic missiles was “several years to a decade away.” Gabbard’s latest testimony suggests that the assessment has not significantly changed. Washington has nonetheless been closely monitoring Pakistan’s missile programme.

According to a well-known Pakistani security analyst, Muhammad Amir Rana, the ATA also reflects views long held by analysts who shape public discourse and are taken seriously by policymakers in Islamabad. Since the Iran-Israel-US crisis escalated last June, some security experts have warned that Iran’s collapse could bring Israel closer to Pakistan’s strategic horizon. Israel and Pakistan see threats in each other as a result of ideological, strategic, and regional factors. Israel’s close links with India and Pakistan’s strong military capabilities and ties with the Gulf states have perhaps contributed to such a view.

Pakistan’s offer to mediate to end the hostilities between Iran, Israel, and the US, as well as to host the mediation in Islamabad, shows that Munir, in particular, is trying to occupy centre stage by emerging as a leading mediator or negotiator. However, his wishful thinking seems misplaced. The US clubbing Pakistan with China, Russia, Iran, and North Korea in the missile-centric assessment is not far from a realistic assessment. The US has raised the red flag on Pakistan’s missile-building capacity, which merits close attention. Allowing Pakistan to woo the US for any mediation on the Iran conflict could perhaps be an error of judgment, leading to serious implications, which only time will tell.

Views expressed are personal

GOVERNANCE GRID



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India’s federal discourse continues to revolve around the Union–state relationship, leaving local governments at the margins despite constitutional backing through the 73rd and 74th Amendments

Decentralisation Without Real Power

Even as India debates cooperative federalism, local governments remain ignored, weakening democracy, limiting grassroots empowerment and exposing structural imbalances in governance practice

When the whole of Tamil Nadu is gearing up to choose a government for another five years, an academic deliberation on a hot topic was planned and conducted in the south of Madurai. It was jointly organised by a research institution, the Academy of Development Affairs, located in the remote village of Usilampatti, and Madurai Kamaraj University, on March 21–22. The discourse focused on the functioning of cooperative federalism in India and its future prospects. Experts were drawn from various universities across Northern India, North East India, and South India. It was interesting to note that a large number of participants from the student community, mostly from Law, Political Science, and Public Administration faculties, actively took part in the deliberation. When it was inaugurated by a vice-chancellor from a central university in Tamil Nadu, he made a fervent plea: whatever the discourse on this topic may be, the key concern should be how a common man can derive maximum benefit from the government, whether it is fully federal or quasi-federal, as he himself comes from a remote village and a rustic family.

The conditions of the poor in villages remain deplorable, even as we achieve 7 per cent economic growth and implement hundreds of development schemes and programmes by governments at both the Union and state levels. An acclaimed expert on federalism, in his inaugural address, analytically traced the historical evolution of federalism in the world, particularly in India, and highlighted the current scenario of relationships among governments globally and within India. The author of this article was invited to deliver a keynote address at this national event. In the keynote address, I highlighted the missing dimension in the discourse on federalism—both in political and academic platforms—namely, the role of local governments in the federal arrangement. While passing the 73rd and 74th Amendments to the Constitution of India in Parliament, and subsequently enacting conformity legislation in all state legislatures, it was argued that a new dimension had been added to Indian federalism and democracy. However, when federalism is taken up for deliberation, academics and researchers usually focus on the



Despite constitutional backing, grassroots institutions remain sidelined in both policy and political discourse

challenges in maintaining harmonious relations between the Union and state governments. Very little attention has been paid to the role of local governments in Indian federalism. It is ironic that the same old framework of analysis continues even after amending the Constitution of India to create a local government system by incorporating Parts IX and IXA. These provisions unequivocally refer to “local government” and not “local bodies.” Federalism remains the basic framework of the Constitution of India.

When we talk about federalism in India, it is necessary to discuss not only the relationship between the Union and the states but also that between the states and local governments. Barring the Union government, the term “local government” is often conveniently avoided, with people continuing to use the outdated phrase “local bodies.” Political parties, both national and regional—barring the Left—have avoided this shift in terminology, aware of its implications: empowering local governments could reduce the relative importance of state governments and elected representatives in Parliament and state legislatures. On many occasions, those in positions of power at the state level feel that strengthening local governments, especially in the context of centralisation of powers amid globalisation, could make state governments vulnerable and marginalised. This explains the reluctance of state governments to genuinely empower local governments. In Tamil Nadu, it has long been argued that decentralisation in India remains incomplete, as powers have not

been sufficiently devolved from the Centre to the states, even as the Centre expects states to devolve more powers to local governments. Since Independence, Dravidian parties have consistently demanded greater autonomy for states.

In the Indian context, symmetrical federalism and pluralist tendencies require strong local governments at the grassroots to address the basic needs of the poor and the marginalised. For a long time, it has been argued that empowering the unreached sections at the grassroots is possible only through vibrant local governments that enable meaningful participation in governance and development. This can be achieved only through strong local institutions. To realise the objectives of the 73rd and 74th Amendments, state governments must take a series of steps to stabilise local governments by conducting regular, free, and fair elections, and by providing adequate powers, finances, and functionalities so that they can function as self-governing institutions. In terms of stability, local governments must be treated on par with the two other tiers—Union and state governments—and not as mere appendages of state administrations.

Yet another glaring omission in the discourse on federalism is the absence of discussion on the legitimate share of local governments in the divisible pool under GST. What local governments ought to receive from this pool remains largely unaddressed. The lack of discourse on the relationship between states and local governments in federal discussions appears to be a deliberate neglect, weakening

the position of the already marginalised and, in turn, undermining democracy at the grassroots. A vibrant federation and democracy require strong local governments. Hence, a new discourse on this subject is urgently needed.

Following the keynote address, there were presentations by academics, researchers, and students. Significantly, the most compelling aspects of the seminar were the questions raised by students during their presentations and discussions, often more thought-provoking than the academic papers themselves. Some of the pressing questions raised by graduate students were: Do we have a politics with civility to deepen democracy? Do political leaders possess the maturity needed to elevate democratic standards? Have we used our liberal democracy honestly and effectively? Do our representatives truly represent their constituents? Contemporary politics appears to lack the decency and decorum essential for a functioning democracy. In the absence of honesty, integrity, and maturity, how can we expect cooperation, coordination, and synergy among governments and political parties to serve the people? Increasingly, political decisions seem to be influenced by market forces. In such a market-driven political environment, can we expect people-centric governance? It is evident that political representatives often serve market interests more than societal ones. Today’s federal politics is marked by authoritarian tendencies rather than genuine governance, leaving little room for the voices of the people. Unless citizens are consciously prepared and empowered, market-driven politics will continue to dominate, benefiting political elites and entrenched interests. Throughout the deliberations, one could sense the anger among the youth over the malfunctioning of India’s federal parliamentary democracy, for which political parties bear significant responsibility. The political space appears to be monopolised by parties, leaving little room for public voice. *Vox populi, suprema lex*—the voice of the people is the supreme law—yet today, market forces often drown out that voice. It is imperative to revive public participation, which calls for a different kind of politics—one that goes beyond party politics.

Views expressed are personal



WHO SAID WHAT



Rajdeep Sardesai @sardesairajdeep

BIG: Government cuts excise duty by Rs 10 on petrol and diesel amid West Asia war. GOOD BUT ...
1. Will the cut only be for a month till elections are over or will it sustain?
2. Did it require a war and a supply crisis for excise duties to be cut?
3. Why weren’t benefits ever passed onto consumer when global oil prices were low?
4. Will states now also pass on the benefit to consumers with duty cuts?
5. Are oil company fuel prices driven by market realities or state intervention, and yes, ELECTION CALENDARS?



Steve Hanke @steve_hanke

President Trump says that “we don’t need the Hormuz Strait. We have so much oil, our country is not affected by this.” TRUMP = CLEARLY UNHINGED = HAS LOST TOUCH WITH REALITY.



PM REVIEWS STATES' READINESS

West Asia crisis: Govt sets up ministerial group led by Rajnath



PM Narendra Modi chairs a virtual meeting with CMs, on West Asia; reviewing preparedness, plans

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government has set up an 'informal group of ministers' led by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh to look into the issues arising due to the West Asia conflict, sources said on Friday. Union ministers Amit Shah, Nirmala Sitharaman and Harddeep Singh Puri are among the members of the informal group of ministers (IGOM), they said. The "arrangement" comes in view of the issues arising due to the impact of the West Asia conflict, the sources said.

The war in West Asia, which began after the US-Israel combine attacked Iran on February 28, prompting retaliatory strikes by Tehran across the Gulf region, has now stretched into four weeks, with no immediate end in sight.

It has impacted the global economy, including oil and gas prices, which have had repercussions on the lives of citizens across the country.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday reviewed the preparedness and plans of the chief ministers of all but poll-bound states in the wake of the West Asia conflict.

HIGHLIGHTS

» Union ministers Amit Shah, Nirmala Sitharaman and Harddeep Singh Puri are among the members of the informal group of ministers

» The 'arrangement' comes in view of the issues arising due to the impact of the West Asia conflict

The virtual meeting was aimed at ensuring synergy of efforts in the spirit of 'Team India', official sources said.

It was the first such meeting the prime minister held with the chief ministers after the conflict broke out in West Asia.

On March 23, Modi had said that the difficult global conditions caused by the West Asia conflict are likely to persist for a long time, and called upon the nation to remain prepared and united, just as it stood together during the Covid-19 pandemic.

In a statement in the Lok Sabha, Modi spoke on the impact of the war on fuel, fer-

tilisers, national security and other areas in India as well as on its nationals living in West Asia, detailing the steps taken by the government to ensure that "ordinary families face as little trouble as possible".

He also said a unanimous voice should go out to the world from India's Parliament on this crisis.

On March 24, Modi announced the constitution of seven empowered groups to deal with the potential long-term impacts of the conflict, and urged the states to work with the Centre in a 'Team India' approach to ward off the crisis. Noting that the situation is constantly changing in West Asia, Modi said its adverse effects are likely to persist for an extended time, and called upon citizens to remain prepared for every eventuality.

On Wednesday, an all-party meeting was convened by the government to discuss the West Asia crisis.

The Union ministers part of the Cabinet Committee on Security, including Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah, S Jaishankar and Nirmala Sitharaman, were part of the meeting along with J P Nadda and Kiren Rijiju.

India signed white shipping info sharing pacts with 5 countries in last 5 yrs: Govt

'White shipping information refers to exchange of information on merchant shipping traffic'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India has signed White Shipping Information Sharing (WSIE) agreements with five countries in the last five years to enhance maritime domain awareness, the government informed Parliament on Friday.

White shipping information refers to the exchange of information on merchant shipping traffic. Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh, in a written response to a query in Lok Sabha, said India has fostered strong bilateral and multilateral partnerships with key partners and like-minded countries in the Indo-Pacific and beyond to ensure Security and Growth for all in the Region (SAGAR).

Expanding on this strategic vision, Prime Minister Narendra Modi outlined the



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

In line with the MAHASAGAR initiative, India continues its commitment to the well-being and progress of nations in the region. . .

MAHASAGAR doctrine -- Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions -- in March 2025 in Mauritius, he said.

"While SAGAR focuses on security and growth within the Indian Ocean Region (IOR), MAHASAGAR expands this

vision to cover the broader Global South. MAHASAGAR encompasses the ideas of trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future," Singh said.

In line with the MAHASAGAR initiative, India

"continues its commitment" to the well-being and progress of nations in the region as a first responder and net security provider in the region.

The government is committed to strengthening maritime cooperation in the IOR and beyond, to ensure a favourable and positive maritime environment. India also participates in regional frameworks to promote maritime cooperation and exchanges in the region, Singh said.

"In line with this vision, India has been focusing on development assistance, capacity building initiatives, economic cooperation, connectivity, HADR (humanitarian assistance and disaster relief) support and defence and maritime security cooperation, to assist countries in the region on sustainable socio-economic development," he said.

UP: 4 children drown in Ganga River

MPOST BUREAU

PRAYAGRAJ: Four children drowned in the Ganga river here on Friday, police said.

The incident took place near Bampur village under the Manda police station limits in the Yamuna Nagar zone when the children had gone to bathe in the river around 10 am, officials said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Yamuna Nagar) Vivek Chandra Yadav said all four children -- Kunal (12), Deepak (17), Nihal (10) and Kamlesh (10) -- drowned while bathing in the river.

He said the bodies of all four victims have been recovered and sent for post-mortem examination. Further legal proceedings are underway.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath took cognisance of the incident and expressed condolences to the bereaved families.

PMLA case: Al Falah group chairman held

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate on Friday said it has again arrested Al Falah Group chairman Jawad Ahmad Siddiqui in a new money laundering case linked to "fraudulent" acquisition of a Rs 45 crore worth land in Delhi.

The 61-year-old was first arrested by the federal probe agency in November 2025 in a different money laundering case linked to the alleged cheating of students of his educational institutions by misrepresenting the accreditation and recognition of his institutions.

The Faridabad- (Haryana) located University came under scrutiny during the probe into a 'white-collar' terror module linked to the November 10,

2025, Red Fort area blast in which 15 people were killed.

One of the doctors at the varsity-cum-hospital, Dr Umar-un-Nabi, is alleged to be the suicide bomber in this case. He died when he was driving an explosive-laden car that day.

Siddiqui was taken into custody in the latest case on March 24 from the Tihar jail, where he is lodged in judicial custody in the previous ED and Delhi Police case, officials said.

He was produced before the special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) located in Saket (south Delhi) the next day and he was sent to ED custody till April 4, the agency said in a statement.

MPOST

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday said that along with strengthening the road network in the state, several concrete steps have been taken to improve road safety.

Efforts are being made to reduce road accidents through identification and improvement of accident-prone locations, modernisation of traffic management systems, awareness campaigns, and the use of new technologies, he said.

The chief minister was addressing a gathering after inaugurating a two-day national seminar on the theme 'Road Safety Solutions', organised by the Indian Roads Congress and the Public Works

Department, Haryana, here.

More than 350 experts, engineers, researchers, policymakers, and academicians, along with distinguished members of the Indian Roads Congress, are participating in the seminar.

The two-day seminar will deliberate on various aspects related to road safety, an official statement said.

Over the past 11 years, 1,719 kilometres of national highways have been constructed for Rs 28,582 crore, ensuring that every district in the state is now connected to the national highway network, Saini said. Saini said that the seminar is an important platform for preparing a roadmap for the country's future.

Here, ideas, technology,

experience, and commitment will come together to move India forward toward becoming safe, strong, and developed, he said. He said that a road is not merely a physical structure; it is the lifeline of development. It connects villages to cities, farmers to markets, youth to opportunities, and the nation to progress.

However, it is also a harsh reality that while roads enable development, road accidents remain a serious concern for society, he said. Expressing serious concern over road accidents, the chief minister said that every year, a large number of people in India fall victim to road accidents. Behind these accidents lie broken families, unfulfilled dreams, and irreparable loss to society.

Rs 40,000 CRORE BANK LOAN 'FRAUD'

ED files chargesheet against ex-RCOM executive

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate on Friday filed a chargesheet against former Reliance Communications president Punit Garg and another person as part of its money-laundering probe into an alleged Rs 40,000 crore bank loan fraud case, official sources said.

The chargesheet was filed before a special court at Rouse Avenue under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The more than 170-page chargesheet names Garg and Vaishali Jairam Mane, a former director at US-based Bonn Investment Inc, as accused in the case, sources said.

The ED arrested Garg, 61, in January this year.

The former Reliance Communications (RCOM) president, while holding senior managerial and directorial posi-

INSIGHT

» The more than 170-page chargesheet names ex-RCOM president Punit Garg and Vaishali Jairam Mane, a former director at US-based Bonn Investment Inc, as accused in the case

» The ED arrested Garg, 61, in January this year

tions in the company from 2001 to 2025, was actively involved in the acquisition, possession, concealment, layering and dissipation of proceeds of crime generated from the said bank fraud, the ED claimed earlier.

The alleged laundered funds were "diverted" through multiple foreign subsidiaries and

offshore entities of RCOM, it alleged.

As the president of RCOM, the agency said, Garg was handling the global enterprise business of the company between 2006 and 2013. He also served as president (regulatory affairs) from 2014 to 2017.

In October 2017, Garg was appointed executive director at RCOM, and from April 2019 till April 2025, he served as a non-executive director of the company, according to the ED.

It was found that the proceeds of crime generated from the alleged fraud were "diverted" to purchase a luxury condominium apartment in Manhattan, New York.

Mane was allegedly linked to the purchase of this Manhattan apartment and has therefore been named in the chargesheet, the ED said.

The property was "fraudulently" sold in 2023 during a corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) of RCOM by Garg, the ED said.

It is understood that RCOM informed the stock exchange about this "fraudulent" sale in 2025.

"The sale proceeds of USD 8.3 million (about Rs 69.55 crore in 2023) were remitted from the US under the guise of a sham investment arrangement with a Dubai-based entity controlled by a Pakistan-linked individual, without the knowledge or consent of the resolution professional (RP)," the agency said. A part of the proceeds of crime -- public money taken by RCOM as bank loans -- was "diverted" for Garg's personal expenses, including overseas education-related payments for his children, the agency claimed. MPOST

Congress to move ECI over 'rigged' RS poll in Hry, says Hooda

CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Friday said the Congress will approach the Election Commission of India against the Returning Officer, alleging manipulation in the recent Rajya Sabha elections. Hooda claimed that four Congress votes were "wrongly cancelled" as part of a conspiracy involving the BJP, and demanded immediate action.

Addressing reporters at his residence, Hooda also targeted the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD), asserting that the party has once again demonstrated its inability to go against the BJP. He alleged that the INLD abstained from voting as it was aware of an assured Congress victory. Despite the cancellation of votes and instances of cross-voting, Hooda maintained that Congress secured 28 votes, while the BJP-backed independent candidate managed only 16. He added that even if the INLD had supported the independent candidate, the outcome would not have changed.

Hooda also criticised the BJP-led government over rising fuel prices and alleged shortages of LPG. He said that while excise duties are being reduced, the benefits are not reaching the public, and prices of petrol and diesel continue to rise.

Referring to long queues for cooking gas, he questioned the government's claim that there is no shortage and accused it of failing to clarify the situation in Haryana.

Raising concerns over law and order, Hooda claimed that Haryana has become one of the most unsafe states, citing the Centre's Social Progress Index.

He also flagged alleged financial irregularities, including a ₹590 crore scam linked to IDFC Bank and a ₹160 crore scam in the Panchkula Municipal Corporation, demanding a thorough probe.

MPOST

UP: CBI busts SIM box cyber fraud racket; two arrested

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has conducted searches at six locations in Uttar Pradesh and arrested two accused persons in connection with a SIM box-based cyber-enabled fraud operation, officials said on Friday.

The accused, identified as Mohd Vilal and Mohd Dilshad, were picked up from Meerut after investigators traced their alleged role in running a network that used bulk SIM cards to carry out fraud calls.

The case pertains to the misuse of bulk SIM cards deployed through SIM box technology for perpetrating large-scale cyber frauds, they said. Investigation revealed that a company was incorporated in January 2025,

in whose name 108 SIM cards were obtained ostensibly for employee use. However, these SIM cards were subsequently flagged by citizens on the National Cyber Reporting Portal (NCRP) and Chakshu portal for their involvement in fraudulent activities, the officials said.

Numerous complaints indicated that these numbers were used to make calls impersonating law enforcement agencies and government officials.

Victims reported being deceived into transferring money following such calls, which typically serve as the initial step in cyber fraud schemes, they added. Following extensive technical analysis and coordinated field operations, two key accused were apprehended from Meerut.

The searches were conducted across six locations in Meerut and Noida, including premises linked to the directors of the company; their associates involved in setting up SIM box infrastructure; the zonal office of a telecom service provider; and an employee of a private entity responsible for verification processes related to bulk SIM issuance.

Investigators seized various electronic devices, including laptops, hard discs, and mobile phones, along with incriminating documents and SIM cards, including one foreign (Nepal) SIM card.

The arrested individuals are directors of the company, which was established "solely to procure bulk SIM cards and facilitate cyber fraud activities".

RAM NAVAMI CELEBRATIONS AT AYODHYA TEMPLE

Surya Tilak lights up Ram Lalla

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: A precisely aligned beam of sunlight falls on the forehead of Ram Lalla at exactly 12 noon on Friday, marking the Surya Tilak ritual on the occasion of Ram Navami at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

The illumination lasts for about nine minutes and draws large numbers of devotees to witness the rare alignment of faith and science. The radiant mark, measuring about 58 mm or 5.8 centimetres, appears on the deity's forehead as sunlight is channelled through a specially designed system. Scientists involved in the process say the exact duration of the tilak remains between three to three-and-a-half minutes, with nearly two minutes of full illumination at the centre.

The arrangement uses a series of mirrors and lenses to direct sunlight with precision into the sanctum. A team of ten Indian scientists stationed at the temple ensures the successful execution of the ritual. The Surya Tilak, first performed in 2024 after trial runs by Bengaluru-based experts, is now carried out with improved



A view of 'Surya Tilak' of Lord Ram at 'Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Temple' in Ayodhya on Friday

accuracy. Temple priest Pandit Satyendra Das says the moment holds deep significance for devotees, describing it as a symbol of divine blessings at the birthplace of Lord Ram after centuries of waiting.

The ritual takes place amid elaborate arrangements and chanting inside the sanctum, where fourteen priests remain present during the moment associated with the birth of Lord Ram. The event is broadcast live through six cameras installed in the temple complex.

On Ram Navami, the tem-

ple sees a surge in footfall, with an estimated one million devotees expected to visit, compared to the usual daily average of around 70,000. Celebrations are also reported from thousands of temples across the region.

To manage the crowd, the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra extends darshan hours from 5 am to 11 pm, three hours longer than the usual schedule. Entry for special category visitors remains restricted for half an hour before and after the Surya Tilak.

The day begins with Mang-

KEY POINTS

» The illumination lasts for about nine minutes and draws large numbers of devotees to witness the rare alignment of faith and science

» The radiant mark, measuring about 58 mm or 5.8 centimetres, appears on the deity's forehead as sunlight is channelled through a specially designed system

ala Aarti at 3:30 am, followed by rituals including Abhishek and Shringar. The deity is dressed in yellow attire and the sanctum is decorated with flowers.

After the ceremonial birth moment, an offering of 56 varieties of food is made to the deity. The offering includes fruits and preparations made from fasting ingredients such as water chestnut flour and buckwheat flour, along with coriander and ram dana panjiri.

The total offering is about 10 quintals and is later distributed among devotees.

MPOST BUREAU

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh High Court has stayed the suspension of a government primary school teacher who allegedly mimicked Prime Minister Narendra Modi in a satirical video on rising LPG prices, observing that the action appeared to have been taken in haste and without due application of mind.

Justice Ashish Shrotri noted that teacher Saket Kumar Purohit was suspended on March 13, the same day BJP MLA Pritam Lodhi sought action against him. The court remarked that the District Education Officer (DEO) failed to assess the "justifiability or desirability" of the suspension and did not contemplate any inquiry before issuing the order.

In its March 25 order, the court observed that as per government guidelines, a public servant can be suspended only when a major penalty is likely. It emphasised that suspension cannot be imposed in a routine manner, cautioning against what it described as a "suspension syndrome".

"The existence of the power



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

The court remarked that the District Education Officer (DEO) failed to assess the 'justifiability or desirability' of the suspension and did not contemplate any inquiry before issuing the order

to suspend an employee, the manner in which such power is exercised, and the propriety of passing such an order are distinct aspects. Merely because

the authority is competent to issue a suspension order does not place such order beyond the scope of judicial review. If it suffers from non-application of mind or is palpably arbitrary, it is liable to be interfered with," the bench said.

Purohit, posted in Shivpuri district, had been accused of uploading an "objectionable" video intended to disturb social harmony and tarnish the image of the education department. Challenging the action, his counsel argued that the video contained no objectionable material and only referred to LPG shortages arising from the West Asia conflict.

The state government contended that suspension does not amount to punishment and falls outside judicial scrutiny. However, the court held that the order appeared to have been passed mechanically, allegedly under the influence of the local MLA.

Setting aside the suspension, the court directed the DEO to reconsider the matter in accordance with the 2005 government instructions. It ordered that the suspension will remain stayed until a fresh decision is taken.

MOVE RAISES GLOBAL TRADE CONCERNS

Iran starts to formalise chokehold on Hormuz with a ‘toll booth’ regime

FRANKFURT: Iran appears to be setting itself up as the gate-keeper for the Strait of Hormuz, the world’s most important artery for oil shipments. The move could cement Tehran’s de facto chokehold over the crucial waterway and formalize its ability to keep its own oil flowing to China.

Iranian communications to the United Nations maritime authority and the experience of ships transiting the strait suggest the creation of something akin to a “toll booth.” Ships must enter Iranian waters and be vetted by Iran’s Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps. At least two vessels have paid for passage.

Traffic through the strait has fallen by 90% since the start of the Iran war, sending global oil prices skyrocketing and inflicting alarming shortages on the Asian nations that get their oil from Persian Gulf countries via the strait.

Only about 150 vessels, including tankers and container ships, have transited since March 1, according to Lloyd’s List Intelligence shipping information firm. That’s a



Cargo ships sail in the Arabian Gulf towards Strait of Hormuz

little more than one day’s normal traffic before the war. Iran’s Kharg Island terminal loaded 1.6 million barrels in March — largely unchanged from prewar monthly loading totals, according to data and analytic firm Kpler. Most of the customers are small, private refineries in China that don’t care about U.S. sanctions.

A majority of the ships that have made it through in recent weeks headed east, out of the Gulf; Iran-affiliated ships accounted for 24% of transits,

Greece 18%, and China 10% counted by ownership or flag registration. Yet on closer examination, vessels connected to Iran accounted for 60% of transits during the first part of the war and in the last few days, some 90%.

About half of the vessels turn off radio identification systems that show their location before going through, and reappear on the other side in the Gulf of Oman. There’s a reason for their reluctance and caution. At least 18 ships have

Summary

» Only about 150 vessels, including tankers and container ships, have transited since March 1, according to Lloyd’s List Intelligence shipping information firm

» Traffic through the strait has fallen by 90% since the start of the Iran war, sending global oil prices skyrocketing in the Asian nations

been hit and at least seven crew members have been killed, according to the U.N.’s International Maritime Organization, which tracks maritime security. It did not specify which nation attacked the vessels.

“Iran’s IRGC has imposed a de facto toll booth’ regime in the Strait of Hormuz,” says shipping information firm Lloyd’s List Intelligence.

Normally ships use a two-lane shipping channel in the middle of the strait. But increasingly, vessels are taking a differ-

ent route, to the north around Larak Island, placing them in Iran’s territorial waters and closer to the Iranian coastline.

Entities that want their vessels to safely pass through must submit their details to what Lloyd’s List Intelligence refers to as “approved intermediaries” of the Revolutionary Guard, including the cargo, owners, destination and a complete crew list. Approved vessels receive a code and are escorted by an IRGC vessel.

“While not all ships are paying a direct toll, at least two vessels have and the payment is settled in yuan,” Lloyd’s List said, referring to the Chinese currency.

On Tuesday, the IMO received a letter from the Iranian government saying it “had implemented a set of precautionary measures aimed at preserving maritime safety and security.” The letter claimed Iran was acting within the principles of international law.

Iran’s parliament appears to be working on a bill to formalize fees for some ships in the Strait of Hormuz, local media reported.

KATHMANDU: Balendra Shah ‘Balen’, who came to the limelight after winning Kathmandu’s 2022 mayoral polls, created history on Friday by becoming the youngest prime minister of the Himalayan nation.

Balen was sworn in as the 47th prime minister days after his Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) registered a massive win in the March 5 parliamentary elections.

The 35-year-old rapper-turned-politician not just became Nepal’s youngest elected prime minister but also the first person from the Madhes region to hold the top executive post in the country.

Balen was a popular choice to lead the interim government after Gen Z youths toppled the K P Sharma Oli-led coalition government in September last year, following two-day nationwide violent protests against corruption and a ban on social media.

But he declined then to lead the interim government, saying he would rather head the government by contesting the parliamentary election for a full term.



Balendra Shah is the youngest PM of Nepal

AP/PTI

Defeated 4-time prime minister KP Sharma Oli by a huge margin

In January, he joined the newly formed RSP, led by Ravi Lamichhane, and was soon declared the party’s prime ministerial candidate.

He defeated four-time prime minister K P Sharma Oli, the chair of Nepal’s legacy party, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist–Leninist) -- CPN-UML -- by a huge margin of about 50,000 votes in Jhapa-5 constituency.

As the Kathmandu Metropolitan City Mayor, Balen is credited with sweeping reform programmes and the beautification of the metropolis. In his resignation letter, Balen said, as the Mayor of Kathmandu, “I have performed my duty in an honest manner as far as possible for the welfare of the metropolis and its inhabitants.”

Born in Kathmandu in a family originally from Madhes province, Balen is the youngest son of Ram Narayan Shah, an Ayurvedic practitioner, and Dhruvadevi Shah, a homemaker. He was keen on music and poetry from a young age and turned to rap music during his education days.

Denmark’s Frederiksen begins coalition talks

COPENHAGEN: Denmark’s Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen and her Social Democrats on Friday began negotiations to form a coalition government, hoping to secure a third term in office despite a massive defeat for her centrist cabinet in Tuesday’s election.

She handed in her resignation to the king of Denmark on Wednesday when it became clear that her bipartisan coalition with the centrist Moderates and the right-wing Liberals could no longer govern.

Analysts said the vote showed a revolt over the cost of living and that many Danes had grown tired of Frederiksen after seven years in power, even though they credited her with standing up to U.S. President Donald Trump over his threats

to annex Greenland.

The need to forge consensus between many small groups in the 12-party parliament will complicate the talks, said Andreas Thyrring, a partner at Ulveman & Borsting, a public affairs advisory firm. “The parties are quite divided on the substance, which also means that, after an election campaign, they may have to back down a bit on some promises,” he said.

Frederiksen already has the Social Liberals and the Left Greens on her side, two left-wing groups that say she should become prime minister, but the Social Democrats must also convince other groups to back them if they are to stay in power. Her party suffered its worst election result since 1903, winning just 38 seats.

Ukraine closes in on Mideast deals to help counter Iranian drones



An Ukrainian soldier prepares to launch a drone

AP

VAUX-DE-CERNAY: Ukraine is close to clinching several security agreements — including with the UAE and Qatar — to counter Iranian attacks, its foreign minister said on Friday, adding that he saw scope to draw China into peace efforts to end the war with Russia.

“We have the situation in the Middle East so it is important not to lose the global attention on the Ukrainian case, because everything is interlinked,” Andrii Sybiha told Reuters in an interview on the sidelines of the G7 foreign ministers meeting in France.

Kyiv is hoping to bolster support in its war against Russia, which is now in its fifth year, as the U.S. Israeli conflict with Iran raises uncertainty over whether Washington will restrict its military supplies.

With President Volody-

myr Zelenskyy currently in the Gulf region, Sybiha said draft accords had been prepared with a number of countries on possible contributions and mutual cooperation, notably on unmanned technologies.

“Hopefully during the visit with some countries, these documents will be concluded and finalised,” he said.

Discussions had been held with Saudi Arabia - with which Zelenskyy earlier on Friday said he had agreed a deal - Kuwait, Jordan and Oman, but the most advanced talks were with the United Arab Emirates and Qatar, Sybiha said.

Sybiha said Gulf Arab countries had used more than 800 Patriot missiles since the war had started to defend themselves, so they now wanted to learn from Ukraine’s experience in shooting down Russian drones and missiles.

AGENCIES

BATTLES SCEPTICISM OVER US’ IRAN WAR PLAN
Rubio’s hard sell meets cold shoulder at G7 talks

VAUX-DE-CERNAY: Group of Seven foreign ministers met in France on Friday to discuss the conflicts in West Asia, and between Russia and Ukraine, with deep divisions apparent over the US-Israel war with Iran following US President Donald Trump’s repeated complaints that US’ allies have ignored or rejected requests for help in confronting Iran’s retaliation, including the closure of the Strait of Hormuz to most of international shipping.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio joined his counterparts from G7 nations only 24 hours after Trump’s latest volley of insults lobbed at NATO, as instability in oil markets persisted with the Iran war entering its fourth week along with uncertainty over the status of potential negotiations to end



Members pose during the meeting on Thursday

AP

the crisis. Most of US’ closest allies have greeted the Iran war with deep scepticism, sentiments that were on display as the G7 foreign ministers met at a historic 12th-century abbey in Vaux-de-Cernay, outside Paris, even as they urged a diplomatic solution to resolve the situation.

As the diplomats gathered,

France’s Minister of the Armed Forces Catherine Vautrin said the war in the Middle East “is not ours”, adding that France’s position is strictly defensive.

Rubio has already faced difficulties in trying to sell the US strategy for the Iran conflict, but Trump’s vitriolic comments about NATO countries not stepping up to help the US and

Pak PM Shehbaz, Kuwait leadership discuss West Asia peace efforts

ISLAMABAD: The Kuwait Crown Prince Sheikh Sabah Al Khaled Al Hamad Al Sabah on Friday called Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif offering support for Pakistan’s “mediation” effort to end the conflict in the West Asia.

According to a statement by the PMO, the prime minister received a telephone call from Al Sabah, who appreciated the Prime Minister’s leadership.

“While expressing deep appreciation of the Prime Minister’s leadership, the Crown

Reiterates Pak’s strong condemnation of the attacks on Kuwait

Prince of Kuwait fully endorsed Pakistan’s efforts for mediation between Iran and the US,” according to the statement.

He also thanked the Prime Minister for Pakistan’s support to Kuwait in the current crisis, also for the Prime Minister for his recent letter of solidarity addressed to the Kuwaiti leadership. The Crown Prince

also expressed his desire to visit Pakistan, as soon as the situation improves.

The PM apprised the Kuwaiti leadership of Pakistan’s sincere diplomatic efforts to bring an end to the war in the West Asia. He also thanked the Crown Prince and assured him that Pakistan would continue to play a constructive role.

Trump’s sign on dollar bills to mark 250th year of US Independence

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump’s signature is set to feature on US paper currency soon, a first for a sitting president since the introduction of dollar bills in 1861.

The decision, taken by the US Treasury, coincides with the 250th anniversary celebrations of American Independence this year.

“In celebration of America’s 250th anniversary, President Donald J Trump’s signature alongside (Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent’s will soon appear

on US currency, marking a first in history, and symbolises @ POTUS’ leadership and dedication to our great nation will carry a lasting impact,” US Treasurer Brandon Beach said in a post on X.

Earlier this month, a federal arts commission approved the final design for a 24-karat gold commemorative coin bearing Trump’s image to help celebrate the 250th anniversary of American Independence.

The 24-karat gold coin, portraying Trump leaning on the

Resolute desk with clenched fists, will be only the second time a living president has featured on a coin. “Under President Trump’s leadership, we are on a path toward unprecedented economic growth, lasting dollar dominance, and fiscal strength and stability,” Bessent said in a statement. “There is no more powerful way to recognise the historic achievements of our great country and President Donald J Trump than US dollar bills bearing his name,” he said.

Three die in chopper crash on Hawaiian island

HANALEI: A tourist helicopter crashed on a remote beach on the Hawaiian island of Kauai, killing three people and injuring two others, authorities said.

The helicopter was carrying one pilot and four passengers when it crashed Thursday afternoon at Kalalau Beach, the Kauai Fire Department said. The beach is on the Na Pali Coast on Kauai’s north shore. The area is otherwise reachable only by hiking or boat.

Police said three people died and two others were transported to Wilcox Medical Centre for treatment. An email was sent to the medical centre seeking the patients’ conditions.

Officials identified the helicopter as being operated by Airborne Aviation, a helicopter company that does sight-seeing tours of Kauai’s canyons, shoreline and waterfalls. Airborne advertises a “doors-off thrill seekers adventure tour” that seats up to four people.

Helicopter tours are a popular way to explore the cliffs, beaches and waterfalls lining the Na Pali Coast.

AGENCIES

Food for thought: Iran war strangles fertiliser supply, food costs to surge

Supply shock hits farms worldwide as world battles urea shortage

HANOI: Farmers around the world are feeling the squeeze of the Iran war. Gas prices have shot up and fertiliser supplies are waning due to Tehran’s near shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz in retaliation for US and Israeli bombing.

The fertiliser shortage is putting the livelihood of farmers in developing countries — already troubled by rising temperatures and erratic weather systems — further at risk, and could lead to people everywhere paying more for food.

The poorest farmers in the Northern Hemisphere rely on fertiliser imports from the Gulf, and the shortage comes just as planting season begins, said Carl Skau, deputy executive director of the World Food Programme. “In the worst case, this means lower yields and crop failures next season. In the best case, higher input costs will be included in food prices next year.”

Iran is seriously limiting



Workers harvest rice at a paddy field in Kishoreganj, Bangladesh

AFP

shipments through the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow passage that usually handles about a fifth of the world’s oil shipments and nearly a third of global fertiliser trade. Nitrogen and phosphate — two major fertiliser nutrients — are under immediate threat from the blockade.

Supplies of nitrogen includ-

ing urea, the most widely traded fertiliser that helps plants grow and boosts yields, are the hardest hit because of shipping delays and the soaring price of liquefied natural gas — an essential ingredient.

The conflict has restricted about 30 per cent of global urea trade, said Chris Lawson of

In Short

» The fertiliser shortage is putting the livelihood of farmers in developing countries — already troubled by rising temperatures and erratic weather systems

» Nitrogen and phosphate — two major fertiliser nutrients — are under immediate threat from the blockade

» The conflict has restricted about 30% of global urea trade

CRU Group, a London-based commodities consultancy.

Some countries are already facing critical shortages, according to Raj Patel, a food systems economist at the University of Texas. For example, Ethiopia gets over 90 per cent of its nitrogen fertiliser from the Gulf through Djibouti, a

supply route that was strained even before the war began in February. “The planting season is now,” Patel said. “The fertiliser isn’t there.”

Phosphate supplies, which support root development, are also under pressure. Saudi Arabia produces about a fifth of the world’s phosphate fertiliser, and the region exports more than 40 per cent of the world’s sulfur, a key ingredient and byproduct of oil and gas refining, Lawson said.

Even after the war ends, producers in the Gulf would need clear security guarantees before resuming shipments through the strait, and insurance costs would almost certainly rise, said Owen Gooch, an analyst with London-based Argus Consulting Services.

“The food system is fragile, and it depends on stable fertiliser supply chains to ensure farmers can produce the food the world relies on,” said Hanna Opsahl-Ben Ammar of Yara International.

World Briefs

BRAZIL’S BOLSONARO LEAVES HOSPITAL, HEADS HOME TO SERVE SENTENCE

SAO PAULO: Brazil’s former President Jair Bolsonaro was discharged from a hospital in the capital on Friday to continue serving a 27-year sentence for a coup attempt at his residence in an upscale gated community. The Supreme Court, earlier in the week, granted him the right of house imprisonment due to failing health. The measure could be revised within 90 days. Bolsonaro left the hospital DF Star in Brasilia at around 10 a.m. local time and headed to the Jardim Botânico neighbourhood, where he lived prior to his conviction, with his wife, Michelle Bolsonaro, and his 15-year-old daughter, Laura.

PRO-IRANIAN HACKERS CLAIM FBI DIRECTOR KASH PATEL ACCOUNT BREACH

WASHINGTON: A pro-Iranian hacking group claimed Friday to have hacked an account of FBI Director Kash Patel and has posted online what appear to be years-old photographs of him, along with a work resume and other personal documents. Many of those records appeared to be more than a decade old. “Kash Patel, the current head of the FBI, who once saw his name displayed with pride on the agency’s headquarters, will now find his name among the list of successfully hacked victims,” said a message posted Friday from the group Handala. The message was accompanied by more than a half dozen photos of Patel, including ones of him standing beside an antique sports car and another with a cigar in his mouth.

Markets dive over 2% on rising oil prices, foreign fund outflows

Tracking the bearish trend in equities, mcap of BSE-listed cos slumped by Rs 8,86,383.92 crore to Rs 4,22,15,450.82 crore (\$4.46 trillion)

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Equity benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled over 2 per cent on Friday after a two-day rally, in tandem with a global selloff, as investor sentiment weakened due to uncertainties over geopolitical tensions.

Crude oil prices staying above the \$100 per barrel mark, the rupee's fall to record lows, and unabated foreign fund outflows also added to the gloom.

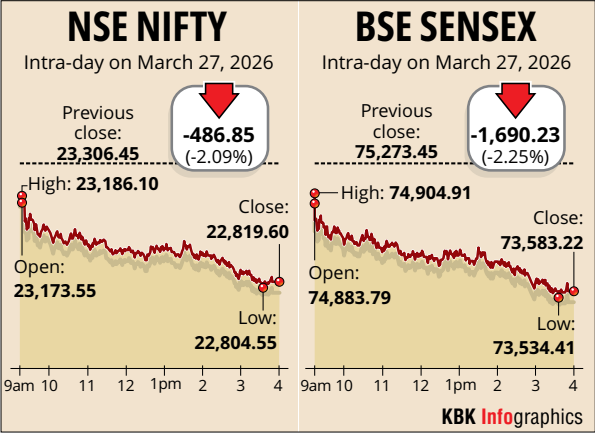
The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,690.23 points, or 2.25 per cent, to settle at 73,583.22. During the day, it plunged 1,739.04 points, or 2.31 per cent, to 73,534.41.

A total of 3,544 stocks declined, while 822 advanced and 135 remained unchanged on the BSE.

Tracking the bearish trend in equities, the market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies slumped by Rs 8,86,383.92 crore to Rs 4,22,15,450.82 crore (\$4.46 trillion).

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 486.85 points, or 2.09 per cent, to end at 22,819.60.

In a holiday-shortened week, the BSE benchmark lost 949.74 points or 1.27 per cent, and the Nifty tanked 294.9



PSU Bank tumbled 3.88%, realty (3.10%), services (2.86%), auto (2.79%), Bankex (2.70%), financial services (2.69%), consumer discretionary (2.52%), consumer durables (2.50%)

points or 1.27 per cent.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Reliance Industries dropped the most by 4.55 per cent, followed by InterGlobe Aviation, Bajaj Finance, State Bank of India, Eternal and HDFC Bank.

In contrast, Tata Consultancy Services, Bharti Airtel and Power Grid were the gainers.

The BSE MidCap Select

index dropped 2.12 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index declined 1.77 per cent.

All sectoral indices ended lower. PSU Bank tumbled 3.88 per cent, realty (3.10 per cent), services (2.86 per cent), auto (2.79 per cent), Bankex (2.70 per cent), financial services (2.69 per cent), consumer discretionary (2.52 per cent), and con-

Highlights

» A total of 3,544 stocks declined, while 822 advanced and 135 remained unchanged on the BSE

» From the 30-Sensex firms, Reliance Industries dropped the most by 4.55 per cent, followed by InterGlobe Aviation, Bajaj Finance, State Bank of India, Eternal and HDFC Bank

» In contrast, TCS, Bharti Airtel & Power Grid were the gainers. The BSE MidCap Select index dropped 2.12%, & SmallCap Select index declined 1.77%

sumer durables (2.50 per cent).

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 1.72 per cent to \$109.9 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors offloaded equities worth Rs 1,805.37 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth Rs 5,429.78 crore.

Rupee falls 89 paise to 94.85 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee tanked 89 paise to close at yet another all-time low of 94.85 against the US dollar on Friday, weighed down by elevated oil prices and a stronger greenback amid uncertainties over the West Asia conflict.

A sharp decline in the domestic equity markets and sustained FII outflows put further pressure on the local unit, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.18 and breached the 94.50-mark for the first time. The domestic unit settled for the day at 94.85 against the US dollar, down 89 paise from its previous close.

The rupee slumped 20 paise to close at a record low of 93.96 against the US dollar on Wednesday. The dollar index, was trading 0.11 per cent higher at 100. PFI

‘India produced 24.23 lakh tons fertiliser in 1st 3 weeks of March’

Output of urea was at 13.55 lakh tonnes, while DAP/NPK and SSP were at 7.62 lakh tonnes and 3.06 lakh tonnes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India produced 24.23 lakh tonnes of fertiliser, including urea and DAP, in the first three weeks of March, notwithstanding the gas supply crunch amid the West Asia crisis, Parliament was informed on Friday.

Of which, urea production was 13.55 lakh tonnes, while Di ammonium Phosphate (DAP)/ NPK and Single Super Phosphate (SSP) were at 7.62 lakh tonnes and 3.06 lakh tonnes, respectively, during March 1-24, Minister of State for Fertilisers Anupriya Patel said in her written reply to the Lok Sabha.

Highlighting the steps taken to ensure smooth gas supply to fertiliser units, the minister said the government has notified fertiliser as a priority sector, ensuring at least 70 per cent gas supply.

“Gas allocation to the fertiliser units has been maintained at 65 per cent of their past six-month average consumption, considering the operational availability,” she said.

To further augment supplies to the Fertilizer sector, an additional 7.31 MMSCMD of natural gas has been procured through the EPMC (Empowered Pool Management Committee) bidding process for the period from March 18 to 31.

“This has resulted in an increase in total gas availabil-



‘The govt has notified fertiliser as a priority sector, ensuring at least 70% gas supply’

ity to the Fertilizer sector to 80 per cent of their past six-month average consumption,” she noted. As of March 23, urea stock was 53.08 lakh tonnes, DAP 21.80 lakh tonnes, Muriate of Potash 7.98 lakh tonnes and NPKs 48.38 lakh tonnes.

Meanwhile, Chemicals and Fertilisers Minister J P Nadda said India has adequate reserves to provide fertilisers to farmers and there is no need to panic.

Replying to a supplementary question in the Lok Sabha on what steps the government is taking to ensure availability amid the ongoing West Asia war, Nadda said he has spoken to state agriculture ministers on

Thursday and informed them about availability of fertilisers.

“I want to assure the citizens of the country the government has taken steps to ensure that fertiliser is available to farmers whenever required. We have sufficient reserves in place. There is not need to panic,” the minister said.

To a supplementary question from Congress member Manish Tewari on whether the government is looking at newer markets for fertiliser imports, Nadda said there is sufficient reserves for kharif season.

“We are also looking for diversification, new markets, newer areas, wherefrom we will get raw materials also for fertilisers. We have framed up our strategy to ensure fertiliser availability,” Nadda said.

Disruption in shipping routes and West Asia war has raised concerns over fertiliser imports. India is a major importer of fertilisers.

RBI injects ₹65,322 cr in banking system via VRR auction



MUMBAI: The RBI on Friday injected Rs 65,322 crore of transient liquidity into the banking system through a six-day variable rate repo (VRR) auction.

The RBI injected the funds at a cut-off rate of 5.26 per cent and a weighted average rate of 5.29 per cent, the central bank said in a release.

The liquidity injected was lower than the notified amount of Rs 75,000 crore, despite the sharp drop in surplus liquidity in the banking system due to advance tax payments and GST outflows.

Currently, liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around Rs 48,698.38 crore as on March 26.

In the last few days, the central bank infused transient liquidity of Rs 2,08,208 crore into the banking system through VRR auctions of various tenures.

Before this, RBI had infused Rs 3.50 lakh crore of durable liquidity into the banking system through open market purchase (OMO) of government securities since January 2026. PFI

Goyal & USTR Greer discuss next steps in India-US BTA negotiations

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Friday held a meeting with US Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer and discussed the next steps in the India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) negotiations.

The two, who met on the sidelines of the 14th ministerial conference (MC14) of the World Trade Organisation at Yaounde, Cameroon, also deliberated upon the issues related to the WTO's meeting.

The four-day meet started on March 26.

“Had a very productive discussion with @USTradeRep Jamieson Greer on the sidelines of the WTO Ministerial Conference. Exchanged views on the #WTOMC14 agenda, next steps in the India-US BTA negotiations and explored ways to further deepen our eco-



nommic cooperation and bilateral trade ties,” Goyal said in a social media post.

The two countries last month announced that they have finalised a framework for the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement. It has not yet been signed.

India and the US announced a trade deal on February 2. A joint statement for the same was released on February 7.

According to the frame-

work, the US had agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent.

However, the tariff architecture in the US has changed following its Supreme Court ruling against President Donald Trump's sweeping tariffs. After that, the US President imposed 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days from February 24.

In view of these changes, a meeting of the chief negotiators of India and the US has been postponed. They were scheduled to meet last month to finalise the legal text of the pact, which was expected to be signed this month.

An official has earlier stated that the interim trade agreement between India and the US will be signed once the new global tariff architecture of America is in place. PFI

‘Healthcare in India must move beyond curative treatments to include preventive, holistic health’

NEW DELHI: India must shift from a treatment-centric healthcare model to one focused on prevention, wellness and community participation, experts said at the 4th Annual Summit on “Advancing Holistic Health through Innovation, Technology, and Tradition”.

Delivering the keynote, former Health Secretary Rajesh Bhushan said healthcare extends beyond curative services to include preventive, promotive, palliative and rehabilitative care, much of which takes place within communities. He noted that rapid urbanisation, lifestyle changes and rising stress are driving a surge in chronic diseases, underscoring the need for proactive and per-



sonalised care models.

Bhushan highlighted the role of digital public health infrastructure such as the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission and ABHA in enabling integrated and efficient healthcare delivery, supported by technologies

like artificial intelligence and machine learning.

Welcoming participants, Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, “The theme of this year's summit... reflects a shift in how we think about

healthcare. For decades, systems have focused on treating illness. The real challenge before us is how to prevent disease and enable people to live healthier, longer and more balanced lives.”

Experts also emphasised integrating traditional systems like Ayurveda, yoga and nutrition with modern medicine to promote holistic well-being. Speakers stressed the importance of awareness, lifestyle changes and community-driven approaches in building a sustainable healthcare ecosystem.

The summit featured discussions on mental health, digital health adoption, and preventive care, along with a special session recognising contributions to the wellness ecosystem. MPOST

A cumulative investment of about Rs 9,207 crore has been made by the approved applicants till December 31

disbursed till date,” he added.

Out of 168 applicants approved under the PLISFPI Scheme, 69 applicants are under the MSMEs category. Two applicants are cooperatives, two applicants are under the sector for innovative food products, and 13 applicants are under the organic sector.

Singh said the scheme aims to support the creation of global food manufacturing champions, promote Indian brands of

NEW DELHI: More than Rs 9,200 crore investments have been made by 168 approved applicants under the production-linked incentive scheme in the food processing sector, the government said on Friday in the Rajya Sabha.

In a written reply, Minister of State for Food Processing Industries Ravneet Singh said, “Under the Production-Linked Incentive Scheme for Food Processing Industries (PLISFPI), 168 applications have been approved as of December 31, 2025.” A cumulative investment of about Rs 9,207 crore has been made by the approved applicants till December 31, 2025.

“Around 35 lakh metric tonnes per annum of processing and preservation capacity has been created under the scheme. Total incentive amount of Rs 2,714.79 crore has been

food products abroad, increase employment opportunities for off-farm jobs, ensure remunerative prices of farm produce and higher income to the farmers.

“The incentives under the PLISFPI are admissible where the entire chain of manufacturing processes, including primary processing, of the food products applied for coverage under the scheme takes place in India,” the minister said.

To a separate query, Singh said that as of January 31, 2026, a total of 41 Mega Food Park projects and 401 Cold Chain projects have been sanctioned, under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Sampada Yojana.

Out of these, 25 mega food park projects and 302 cold chain projects have become operational, and the remaining are at various stages of implementation, the minister said. PFI

BYD opens its 48th India showroom in Moti Nagar

NEW DELHI: BYD India, a subsidiary of BYD and the world's No. 1 NEV (New Energy Vehicle) manufacturer, on Friday announced the inauguration of its 48th showroom in India and sixth showroom in Delhi NCR, located in Moti Nagar.

The new facility, the largest BYD showroom in India, has been launched in partnership with PPS Motors Pvt. Ltd., marking the sixth BYD showroom operated by PPS Motors apart from four service workshops in 3 states in India and further strengthening the brand's retail presence in the region.

The newly inaugurated outlet reinforces BYD India's

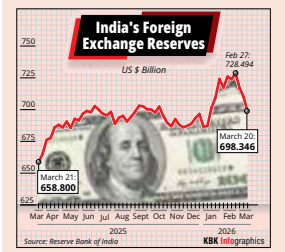
expanding presence in Delhi NCR, one of the country's fastest-growing and most dynamic electric vehicle markets.

The expansion reflects the brand's commitment to making advanced electric mobility solutions more accessible to customers in the region.

Spanning 9,000 sq. ft., the Moti Nagar facility is designed to provide customers with an expansive and immersive retail experience.

The showroom will display BYD's advanced electric passenger vehicles while enabling customers to explore the brand's cutting-edge technology, design philosophy, and sustainable mobility innovations. MPOST

Forex stocks fall \$11.413 bn to \$698.346 bn



MUMBAI: India's forex reserves dropped by \$11.413 billion to \$698.346 billion during the week ended March 20 due to a sharp decrease in gold reserves, the RBI said on Friday.

The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year, before the onset of the West Asia conflict.

For the week ended March 20, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased by \$2.127 billion to \$557.695 billion, the central bank's data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

However, the value of gold reserves decreased by \$13.495 billion to \$117.186 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were down \$65 million to \$18.632 billion, the apex bank said. India's reserve position with the IMF was up by \$19 million to \$4.833 billion in the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data. PFI

NeuEN Green Energy bags 10K TPA green hydrogen contract from NRL

NEW DELHI: NeuEN Green Energy Pvt Ltd. (NeuEN), a 50:50 joint venture between Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) & Sembcorp Green Hydrogen India Private Ltd, has secured a contract to supply 10,000 tonnes per annum (TPA) of green hydrogen to Numaligarh Refinery Ltd. (NRL).

Under the contract, NeuEN will develop a green hydrogen production facility at NRL's refinery in Assam, supported by a long-term offtake arrangement.

The project is expected to begin commercial oper-

ations in 2028 and will integrate renewable energy with advanced storage solutions to enable reliable, round-the-clock operations to support refinery decarbonisation.

Sanjay Khanna, Chairman & Managing Director, BPCL, said, “This project marks a significant milestone in BPCL's journey towards building a future-ready and resilient energy portfolio. Through NeuEN, we are strengthening our presence across the green hydrogen value chain and progressing towards becoming a supplier of clean energy solutions. MPOST

Govt disburses incentives worth ₹15,554 cr so far under PLI scheme for electronics sector

‘Overall, PLI schemes have attracted investments of over Rs 2.16 lakh crore’

NEW DELHI: The government on Friday said it has disbursed incentives worth Rs 15,554 crore so far under the production-linked incentive scheme (PLI) for the electronics sector.

Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada said that under the automobiles and auto components sector, about Rs 2,377.56 crore of incentives have been disbursed so far.

“Under the electronics sector (large-scale electronics manufacturing and IT hardware



2.0), about Rs 15,554 crore of incentives have been disbursed,” he said. He added that overall, the PLI schemes have attracted investments of over Rs 2.16 lakh crore.

It has generated incremen-

tal production worth about Rs 4,20,581 crore in this financial year up to December 2025.

The PLI schemes have been launched for 14 sectors with an outlay of about Rs 1.91 lakh crore, to strengthen the manufacturing ecosystem and enhance exports.

“As of December 2025, a cumulative incentive of Rs 28,748 crore has been disbursed,” he said in another reply.

The minister informed that Rs 6,022 crore was disbursed for the pharma sector till Decem-

ber last year.

It was Rs 1,859 crore for telecommunication, Rs 2,163 crore for food products, Rs 55 crore for bulk drugs, Rs 157 crore for medical devices, Rs 281 crore for white goods, Rs 93 crore for drones, Rs 81 crore for IT hardware, Rs 55 crore for textiles, and Rs 132 crore for speciality steel.

There is no disbursement for PLI schemes for High Efficiency Solar PV Modules and Advanced Chemistry Cell (ACC) Battery. PFI

Govt invests ₹258 cr under Electronics Development Fund to support 128 startups

NEW DELHI: The government has invested Rs 257.77 crore under the Electronics Development Fund (EDF) in eight “Daughter funds”, which in turn have given financial support to 128 startups & firms, Parliament was informed on Friday.

Daughter funds are specialized investment vehicles or sub-funds that receive capital from a larger “mother” fund or government-backed entity to invest in specific sectors, startups, or MSMEs.

The Minister of state for electronics and IT Jitin Prasada in a written reply to Rajya Sabha

said that the EDF was set up as a Fund of Funds to invest in “Daughter funds” and it provides risk capital to companies developing emerging technologies in the area of electronics, nano-electronics and IT.

“As on February 28, 2026, EDF has invested Rs 257.77 crore in eight Daughter funds, which in turn have made investments of Rs 1,335.77 crore in 128 companies/startups. Total employment in supported companies is more than 22,700. The number of IPs created/acquired by the supported companies are more than 300,” he said. PFI

TO FUND FISCAL DEFICIT

Centre plans to borrow ₹8.20L cr from mkt during April-Sept FY27

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre is planning to mobilise Rs 8.20 lakh crore through dated securities during the April-September period of 2026-27 to fund the revenue gap, the Finance Ministry said on Friday.

Gross Market Borrowings in BE 2026-27 were Rs 17.20 lakh crore. Since the Budget presentation, switches of G-Sec were conducted, reducing Gross Market borrowing to Rs 16.09 lakh crore, it said.

“Of Rs 16.09 lakh crore, Rs 8.20 lakh crore (51 per cent) is planned to be borrowed in H1 through issuance of dated securities, including Rs 15,000 crore of Sovereign Green Bonds (SGrBs),” it said.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, in the Budget, proposed to borrow Rs 17.2 lakh crore to fund its fiscal deficit projected at 4.3 per cent of the GDP.

In absolute terms, the fiscal deficit is pegged at Rs 16.9 lakh crore for 2026-27.

“To finance the fiscal deficit, the net market borrowings from dated securities are estimated at Rs 11.7 lakh crore. The balance financing is expected to come from small savings and other sources. The gross market borrowings are estimated at Rs 17.2 lakh crore,” she had said while delivering the Bud-



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, in the Budget, proposed to borrow Rs 17.2 lakh crore to fund its fiscal deficit projected at 4.3 per cent of the GDP

get 2026-27.

According to the statement, the Gross Market Borrowings of Rs 8.2 lakh crore shall be completed through 26 weekly auctions.

The market borrowing will be spread over 3, 5, 7, 10, 15, 30, 40 and 50-year securities, it said.

The share of borrowing (including SGrBs) under different maturities will be: 3-year (8.1 per cent), 5-year (15.4 per cent), 7-year (8.1 per cent), 10-year (29 per cent), 15-year (14.5 per cent), 30-year (7.3 per cent), 40-year (8 per cent) and 50-year (9.6 per cent).

To enable institutional and retail investors to plan their investments efficiently and to provide transparency and stability to the Government Securities market, the government, in consultation with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), plans to do weekly borrowing ranging from Rs 28,000 crore to Rs 34,000 crore during the period.

All the auctions covered by the calendar will have the facility of non-competitive bidding under which five per cent of the notified amount will be reserved for the specified retail investors, it said.

Highlights

- » Gross Market Borrowings in BE 2026-27 were Rs 17.20 lakh crore
- » ‘Since the Budget presentation, switches of G-Sec were conducted, reducing Gross Market borrowing to Rs 16.09 lakh crore’
- » ‘Of Rs 16.09 lakh cr, Rs 8.20 lakh cr is planned to be borrowed in H1 via dated securities, including Rs 15K cr of Sovereign Green Bonds’

Like in the past, it said, the government, in consultation with the RBI, will continue to have the flexibility to bring about modifications in the above calendar in terms of notified amount, issuance period, maturities, etc. and to issue different types of instruments, including instruments having non-standard maturity, floating rate bonds (FRBs), inflation indexed bonds (IIBs), depending upon the requirement, evolving market conditions and other relevant factors, after giving due notice to the market.

The calendar is subject to

change, if circumstances so warrant, including for reasons such as intervening holidays, it said.

About switch/buyback of dated securities through auction, it said, they are done to smoothen the redemption profile.

“Switches of dated securities through auction will be conducted on the third Monday of every month or at more frequent intervals. In case the third Monday is a holiday, the switch auction will be conducted on the fourth Monday of the month,” it said.

The Centre will continue to reserve the right to exercise the greenshoe option to retain an additional subscription of up to Rs 2,000 crore against each of the securities indicated in the auction notifications, it said.

Weekly borrowing through issuance of Treasury Bills (T-Bills) in the first quarter (Q1) of FY 2026-27 is expected to be Rs 24,000 crore for 12 weeks with issuance of Rs 12,000 crore under 91-day T-Bills, Rs 6,000 crore under 182-day T-Bills and Rs 6,000 crore under 364-day T-Bills.

To take care of temporary mismatches in government accounts, the Reserve Bank has fixed the Ways and Means Advances (WMA) limit for first half of FY 2026-27 at Rs 2.50 lakh crore.

Trump’s Iran war pushes India to rekindle friendship with Russia

India became a major buyer of Russian crude that was heavily discounted after the invasion of Ukraine

discounted after the invasion of Ukraine, which became a point of contention with the Trump administration.

The world’s third-biggest oil importer and consumer purchased nearly \$44 billion of crude from Moscow last year, playing a vital role in keeping the Kremlin’s wartime economy alive, *Reuters* reported.

India has separately told its energy importers to get ready to resume purchases of Russian LNG, one of the people said. Delhi has already approached Washington about a possible sanctions waiver, according to the source and a second person familiar with the request.

Foreign ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told reporters last week that Delhi was in talks with several countries to secure energy supplies, including LNG. Indian authorities have also said they are purchasing cargos of Russian liquefied petroleum gas, which is largely used for cooking and isn’t under sanctions.

The Russian energy ministry declined to comment about any discussions with India, while the US Treasury Department did not address questions about sanctions relief. “India chose

the course that best served its national interests, anchored in a long-standing and trusted partnership with Russia,” said Ajai Malhotra, a former Indian ambassador to Moscow.

Delhi should now “demand exemptions or accommodations as a normal part of negotiation between strategic partners,” he added, referring to Washington.

While India has been courted by the United States for decades as a strategic counterweight to neighbouring China, the world’s fifth-largest economy has now been left reeling twice in less than a year by decisions initiated largely in Washington. After years of buying crude oil from Moscow at discounted rates, Delhi sharply curtailed purchases after Trump in August imposed tariffs of as high as 50 per cent on Indian goods, or among the most punitive levied on any country. The US Supreme Court has since ruled that Trump acted unlawfully in enacting such tariffs.

India’s calculus quickly changed after the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28.

Demand for Russian energy exports, which when transported to Asian customers avoid the Gulf, has sharply increased across the region’s economies.

India’s state-owned refiners began ordering additional purchases of Russian crude in the hours before the US on March 5 announced a temporary waiver that would allow Delhi to buy some sanctioned cargoes. As oil prices continued to climb, Washington further loosened restrictions. AGENCIES

RBI imposes fine on 3 govt banks, Pine Labs for non-compliance

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) imposed monetary penalties on Union Bank of India, Bank of India, Central Bank of India, and Pine Labs for non-compliance with certain directions.

It imposed Rs 95.40 lakh penalty on Union Bank of India, Rs 63.60 lakh on Central Bank of India, Rs 58.50 lakh on Bank of India, and Rs 3.10 lakh on Pine Labs, the RBI said in a release.

Monetary penalty on the Union Bank of India was imposed as lender did not credit the amount involved in the unauthorised electronic transaction to certain customers’ accounts within 10 working days from the date of such notification by the customer, did not provide customers with 24x7 access to report unauthor-

‘It imposed Rs 95.40 lakh penalty on Union Bank of India, Rs 63.60 lakh on Central Bank of India, Rs 58.50 lakh on Bank of India, and Rs 3.10 lakh on Pine Labs’

ised banking transactions, and resorted to manual intervention in the System-based asset classification process in certain KCC accounts, as per release.

In the case of the Central Bank of India, the penalty was imposed as the bank failed to upload the KYC records of certain customers onto the

Central KYC Records Registry within the prescribed timeline, and opened additional BSBD (Basic Savings Bank Deposit) accounts of certain customers, who were already holding BSBD accounts in the bank.

Bank of India was penalized for collecting ad-hoc service charges/inspection charges/processing charges in certain priority sector loan accounts, and not paying interest on certain Term Deposit Receipts (TDRs) from the date of maturity till the date of their repayment, release added.

The central bank said Pine Labs issued several Full-KYC Prepaid Payment Instruments (PPIs) without completing the Know Your Customer (KYC) of the PPI holders, due to which the penalty was imposed. PTI

Unemployment dips to 3.1% in 2025: Survey

NEW DELHI: The overall unemployment rate for persons aged 15 years and above in the country declined marginally to 3.1 per cent in January to December 2025 from 3.2 per cent a year ago, stated a government survey released on Friday.

Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2025, released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, said the unemployment rate (UR) estimates indicate sustained progress in reducing unemployment across sectors and genders.

The study showed the UR among females in the country remained unchanged at 3.1 per cent in 2025 compared to the year-ago level, while for males it came down to 3.1 per cent in 2025 from 3.3 per cent.

Rural unemployment rates in 2025 stood at 2.4 per cent, marginally lower than 2.5 per cent a year ago, showing

strong rural labour absorption, it stated.

The female unemployment rate remained low at 2.1 per cent, lower than the male UR in rural areas, which stood at 2.6 per cent.

The male and female unemployment eased to 4.2 per cent and 6.4 per cent, respectively.

The percentage distribution of workers (in usual status) by status in employment indicates a modest shift in the composition of employment in 2025, it stated.

The share of self-employment declined slightly from 57.5 per cent in 2024 to 56.2 per cent in 2025 at the overall level, with reductions observed for both male (52.9 per cent to 52 per cent) and female (66.5 per cent to 64.2 per cent).

It explained that this moderation has been accompanied by an increase in the share of regular wage/salaried employ-

ment, which rose from 22.4 per cent to 23.6 per cent; the increase is visible for both male (25.4 per cent to 26.5 per cent) and female (16.6 per cent to 18.2 per cent).

The share of workers engaged in casual labour has remained broadly stable at around one-fifth of total employment (20 per cent in 2024 to 20.2 per cent in 2025), with only marginal variations across gender, it stated.

The percentage distribution of workers (in usual status) by industry of work reflects a broadly stable sectoral composition in 2025 with some notable shifts.

Agriculture continues to account for the largest share of employment, though it has decreased from 44.8 per cent in 2024 to 43.0 per cent in 2025.

The share of employment in construction has decreased marginally (12.3 per cent to 12

per cent), while manufacturing has seen improvement from 11.6 per cent to 12.1 per cent.

Other services have also recorded an increase (12.2 per cent to 13.1 per cent).

Earnings of workers have shown a notable improvement in recent years across categories, with gains observed for both males and females in nominal terms.

In regular wage/salaried employment, average earnings for males increased from Rs 22,891 in 2024 to Rs 24,217 in 2025 (about 5.8 per cent growth), while for females, earnings rose from Rs 17,126 to Rs 18,353 (about 7.2 per cent rise). In self-employment, male earnings increased from Rs 16,893 in 2024 to Rs 17,914 in 2025 (around 6 per cent growth), while female earnings rose from Rs 5,861 to Rs 6,374 (around 8.8 per cent increase). PTI

RBI fixes H1 WMA limit for govt at ₹2.5 lakh cr



MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday fixed the limit for Ways and Means Advances (WMA) for the first half of 2026-27 at Rs 2.5 lakh crore to help the central government meet any temporary mismatch in receipts and payments.

The Reserve Bank of India may trigger fresh floatation of market loans when the central government utilises 75 per cent of the Ways and Means Advances limit, the apex bank said in a statement.

“Reserve Bank of India, in consultation with the Government of India, has decided that the limit for Ways and Means Advances (WMA) for the first half of the financial year 2026-27 (April to September 2026) will be Rs 2,50,000 crore,” it said.

The Reserve Bank of India also said it retains the flexibility to revise the WMA limit at any time, taking into consideration the prevailing circumstances.

The interest rate on WMA will be equal to the repo rate, and on overdraft, 2 per cent above the repo rate. PTI

Adani Ports and SEZ sets up India’s first Port of Refuge to boost maritime emergency infra

AHMEDABAD: Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) has operationalised India’s first Port of Refuge (PoR), addressing a long-standing gap in maritime emergency infrastructure, creating a structured mechanism to handle maritime emergencies and vessels in distress.

A PoR is a designated location where ships can seek shelter to stabilise conditions, protect life and limit environmental damage. While such frameworks are standard in major maritime economies, India had not formalised one until now. The move comes as India, with a coastline of over 11,000 kilometres and located along key global shipping routes, seeks



(L to R): Aenna Jagga, Head Business Development, APSEZ; Ketan Gajjar, CEO, MERC; Ashwini Gupta, CEO, APSEZ; Richard Janssen, CEO, SMIT; Shyam Jagannathan, DG, shipping; Sushil Mansingh Khopade, Additional DG, shipping

to strengthen its emergency response capabilities.

APSEZ will designate two sites as PoR: Dighi Port on the west coast, supporting traffic across the Arabian Sea and routes to the Persian

Gulf and Gopalpur Port on the east coast, serving vessels in the Bay of Bengal and routes towards the Malacca Strait, one of the world’s busiest maritime trade corridors. The facilities will provide salvage and wreck

removal, firefighting, pollution containment and emergency coordination services through specialised equipment and trained response teams.

The initiative is backed by a tripartite memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with SMIT Salvage, the salvage and emergency response division of Royal Boskalis Westminster NV (Boskalis) and the Maritime Emergency Response Centre (MERC), bringing global expertise and coordinated response capability. The capability will support vessels insured under the International Group of Protection and Indemnity (P&I) Clubs, aligning with global maritime risk & liability frameworks. MPOST

‘Housing sales up 9% to 1.01L units in Jan-March across top seven cities’

NEW DELHI: Housing sales rose 9 per cent annually to over 1.01 lakh units in January-March across top-seven cities on low-base effect but fell 7 per cent from the previous quarter amid global economic uncertainties due to the West Asia conflict, according to Anarock.

Sales increased to 1,01,675 units during the current quarter from 93,280 units in the year-ago period.

Real estate consultant Anarock said the sales in value terms grew 6 per cent to Rs 1.51 lakh crore during the January-March period from Rs 1.42 lakh crore in the corresponding period of the preceding year.

Anarock, however, pointed out that housing sales fell 7 per



cent in volume terms and 6 per cent value wise from the previous quarter because of West Asia conflict.

In the fourth quarter of the last calendar year, 1,08,970 units were sold for Rs 1.60 lakh crore.

Anuj Puri, Chairman of Anarock Group, said, “While India’s residential segment’s long-term fundamentals remain strong, the short-term tremors

of the Iran War were clearly visible in the first quarter. The 7 per cent dip in sales tracks the war-induced uncertainty, with sentiment and sales clearly affected by surging oil and construction prices — particularly in March.”

“The decline also aligns with large numbers of prospective Middle Eastern homebuyers, who invest significantly in Indian real estate, hitting the pause button under the war cloud,” he added.

Mumbai-based Anarock is one of the leading housing brokerage firms in the country. It also provides consultancy services for leasing of commercial (office, retail and warehousing) real estate spaces, land acquisition and fund raising. PTI

Govt hikes commercial LPG supply to 70% of pre-war demand

NEW DELHI: The central government has increased commercial LPG (liquefied petroleum gas) allocations to states by 20 per cent, raising the quota to 70 per cent of pre-war demand to meet industrial requirements, including steel and automobiles.

In a letter to state chief secretaries, Oil Secretary Neeraj Mittal directed that the additional supply be prioritised for labour-inten-

sive industries such as steel, automobiles, textiles, dyes, chemicals, and plastics, which support other essential sectors.

“In addition to the existing 50 per cent allocation, an additional 20 per cent is now proposed, that would bring the total commercial LPG allocation to 70 per cent of the pre-crisis level of the packed non-domestic LPG,” the oil secretary wrote. PTI

‘Indian aviation sector outlook negative, weak near-term demand’

The ratings agency expects domestic air passenger traffic growth to be at 0-3% for the ongoing fiscal year

MUMBAI: Ratings agency ICRA on Friday revised its outlook on the Indian aviation industry to negative from stable, citing disruptions in international airspace following escalation of geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

The revision in outlook is also on account of a sharp depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar and an expected increase in jet fuel (ATF) prices, ICRA said. These factors are likely to significantly increase cost pressures for airlines, even as demand growth faces downside risks, it said.

The ratings agency expects domestic air passenger traffic growth to be at 0-3 per cent for the ongoing fiscal year and international passenger traffic growth for Indian carriers at 7-9 per cent, indicating a relatively weak near-term demand environment.

Prior to the West Asian crisis, ICRA had estimated domestic air passenger traffic growth at 6-8 per cent and international traffic growth for Indian carriers at 8-10 per cent for FY27.

However, these projections now carry a downward bias, it said.

CLOSER LOOK

- » The revision in outlook is also on account of a sharp depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar and an expected increase in jet fuel (ATF) prices, ICRA said
- » ICRA expects international passenger traffic growth for Indian carriers at 7-9 per cent for current fiscal
- » Flight cancellations due to airspace closures, coupled with higher airfares following the levy of fuel surcharges, are expected to weigh on passenger traffic growth

Flight cancellations due to airspace closures, coupled with higher airfares following the levy of fuel surcharges (estimated at 5-6 per cent of aver-

age ticket prices), are expected to weigh on passenger traffic growth, ICRA said.

Additionally, rerouting of flights is likely to increase fuel

burn and operating costs, the ratings agency said. Moreover, the removal of airfare caps by the DGCA, which were introduced in December last year following operational disruptions at IndiGo poses further downside risks.

A sharp rise in ticket prices could dampen travel demand going forward, ICRA said.

ICRA had earlier projected net losses for the aviation industry to narrow to Rs 11,000-12,000 crore in FY27, supported by traffic growth.

However, the recent geopolitical developments, along

with adverse currency movements and rising fuel costs, have introduced a downward bias to these estimates, it said, adding that for FY26, the industry is expected to report net losses of Rs 17,000-18,000 crore.

The pressure on profitability is being exacerbated by structural cost challenges. Fuel alone accounts for 30-40 per cent of airlines’ operating expenses, while 35-50 per cent of total costs, including lease payments and maintenance, are dollar-denominated, making airlines highly vulnerable to currency depreciation, ICRA added. PTI

Summertime madness

RCB kick off IPL in charged Bengaluru, tribute marks stadium tragedy

S KANNAN

BENGALURU: If it's summer, the Indian Premier League (IPL) is never far behind. In Bengaluru, home to Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB), the buzz is unmistakable. From die-hard fans to politicians, the scramble for tickets and passes has reached a fever pitch — even as memories linger of June 4, 2025, when a stampede at the Chinnaswamy Stadium claimed 11 lives.

In tribute, the Karnataka State Cricket Association, led by president Venkatesh Prasad, has decided to keep 11 seats vacant this season. The gesture goes beyond symbolism — a reminder that the tragedy cannot be forgotten.

From Saturday, however, attention shifts to the field. RCB face Sunrisers Hyderabad in the opening clash, and with security tightened and crowd control measures in place, the city is ready. After weeks of uncertainty, Bengaluru will host the opener, much to the relief of fans and organisers alike.

IPL followers are known for their passion. Many have arrived in the city without tickets, hoping for a glimpse of Virat Kohli, whose aura contin-



RCB's Virat Kohli bats at nets on Friday

PTI

ues to draw crowds. Defending champions RCB, led by Rajat Patidar, will be under pressure from the outset.

Sunrisers Hyderabad, captained by Ishan Kishan with Abhishek Sharma as his deputy, begin their campaign without

Pat Cummins, who is recovering from injury. The Australian is expected to return later in the tournament, but SRH will aim to start strongly regardless.

The IPL's enduring appeal lies in its star power and deep talent pool. Chennai Super

Kohli's very hungry and on top of his game: Flower

BENGALURU: The 18 passing IPL summers have not affected Virat Kohli's "drive and hunger" to touch new heights as a sportsperson, and still remains on top of his game, reckoned Royal Challengers Bengaluru head coach Andy Flower here on Friday. Kohli was RCB's leading run-getter last year, scoring 657 runs when the franchise landed its maiden IPL trophy.

"I've been watching really closely (Kohli batting at nets), he looks on top of his game, he looks super fit. I was watching him do shuttles the other day, he looks light on his feet, very fit, very lean, very hungry," said Flower. "He's always been very hungry and determined and I think that mental and emotional space that he's in, where he's very comfortable with himself as a person, but he's also very hungry to drive himself as a professional sportsperson," he added.

AGENCIES

Kings still enjoy a massive following, with MS Dhoni at the helm. The addition of Sanju Samson only strengthens their batting firepower.

Across teams, expectations run high. Shubman Gill will look to lead Gujarat Titans from the front, while Shreyas Iyer remains key to Punjab's ambitions. Mumbai Indians, led by Hardik Pandya, boast formidable depth, with Rohit Sharma, Suryakumar Yadav and Jasprit Bumrah forming a core that can turn matches.

Elsewhere, Axar Patel leads Delhi Capitals with quiet confidence, while Rishabh Pant's return to fitness is a boost for Lucknow Super Giants. Rajasthan Royals will keep an eye on young sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, while Kolkata Knight Riders, under Ajinkya Rahane, aim for a stronger showing this season.

The IPL is as much about its fans as its cricket. Packed schedules, high intensity and relentless travel make it a grueling competition — but one players have come to embrace.

DOMINATE WITH MIXED TEAM GOLD

10/10 for compound archers as India rule the roost at Asia Cup

BANGKOK: Indian compound archers delivered a dominant performance, clinching the mixed team gold and women's team silver, while also sweeping the men's individual podium at the Asia Cup-World Ranking Tournament Stage 1, here on Friday.

India also bagged two silver medals in the recurve section in the afternoon session to take their tally to two gold, four silver and four bronze, surpassing their eight-medal haul at the previous edition.

But in gold medal count, India fared poorly as compared to the last edition when they clinched five yellow metals.

It boiled down to their poor show in the recurve section where none of the archers could manage a gold, while they returned empty-handed in men's individual section and mixed team event.

In 2025, India had a gold-silver finish in men's recurve individual, while mixed team bagged a silver.

The highlight of the day was a clean sweep in the men's compound individual section, where Uday Kamboj edged past Prathamesh Jawkar 145-144 in a thrilling all-Indian final to clinch his maiden international gold,



Uday Kamboj won his first international gold medal

WORLD ARCHERY

India also bagged two silver medals in the recurve section in the afternoon session

while seasoned campaigner Rajat Chauhan secured a bronze.

It was an ice cool Chauhan who confirmed the Indian clean sweep when he used all his experience to drill in three perfect arrows in the final end to down local favourite Peerawat Rattanapongkiat 145-144 in a tense bronze playoff.

It also confirmed a clean sweep by the country's archers

in the event as it was an all-Indian final in the following match.

Kamboj stuns Jawkar
In a battle of two 22-year-olds, comeback man Kamboj emerged victorious in a closely-fought contest against the more decorated Prathamesh Jawkar, winning 145-144 to claim his maiden international gold.

The match saw momentum fluctuating, with former World Cup and Asian Games gold medallist Jawkar leading 59-57 after the second end.

Kamboj, however, bounced back to level the scores at 87-87 in the third end before capitalising on a slight lapse from his opponent in the fourth end to take a 116-115 lead.

AGENCIES

'GOING TO HAVE ONE SQUAD FOR WC & ASIAD'

All in one? Fulton bats for same team

NEW DELHI: Indian men's hockey chief coach Craig Fulton on Friday said that the same team will play in this year's FIH World Cup and Asian Games, dismissing suggestions that two different squads will represent the country due to the close proximity of the two important events.

He insisted that he will have one squad and the selections will "base around that".

As the World Cup and the Asian Games are just three weeks apart, there was speculation that India is planning to field two different teams to manage player fitness and workload.

While the World Cup will be held in Belgium and the Netherlands from August 15 to



Harmanpreet Singh with Craig Fulton during training

FILE

30, the Asian Games, which is an Olympic qualifier, is scheduled to be held in Japan from September 19 till October 4.

"No, we are going to have

one squad and we are going to base it around that," Fulton said on the sidelines of the eighth Hockey India Annual Awards here on Friday.

AGENCIES

Tonali sets the tone for Italy at WC playoffs



Sandro Tonali starred for Italy against Northern Ireland

AP

BERGAMO: Italy finally won a match in the World Cup playoffs. Now the four-time champions need to win one more to avoid failing to qualify for a third straight time.

The Azzurri beat Northern Ireland 2-0 in the European semifinals on Thursday.

Sandro Tonali broke the deadlock with a half-volley early in the second half for Italy at home in Bergamo and then set up another goal for Moise Kean.

"After taking the lead, we cleared our minds," Italy coach Gennaro Gattuso said. "We put in a good performance. This should be a confidence boost for Tuesday. ... We have to win. We have no other choice."

Also advancing to the playoff finals scheduled for Tuesday were Bosnia and Herzegovina, Sweden, Poland, Turkey, Kosovo, Denmark and the Czech Republic.

France beat Brazil
FOXBOROUGH (USA): The traffic on the way to France's World Cup tune-up against Brazil was a problem. Kylian Mbappé's knee was not.

The former Paris Saint-Germain and current Real Madrid star showed no ill effects from his knee injury on Thursday when he broke free for a goal to give France an early lead on its way to a 2-1 victory in a friendly between two of the world's top teams.

AGENCIES

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

L. No.: - Dy.CE/PE/AGC/25-26 Dt: 27.03.2026

PUBLIC NOTIFICATION

Notice is given to all user of Railway line and premises situated on the completed section of Chhata Station of North Central Railway, 2x25 kV Chhata/TSS will be energized on or after 29/03/2026 in the following section around the Railway line. On or from this date the over head line will at all times be treated as a live line and no unauthorized person shall approach or work in the proximity of the said over head line.

Date of Energization On or after 29.03.2026

Section	KM/Location/Chainage From	To
Energization of New 2x25 kV Chhata/TSS in connection with raising of speed to 160 Km/h/200 Km/h. Design, Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of 132/2x25 kV Traction Sub-station along with SP/SSPs between Palwal-Mathura on existing New Delhi-Mumbai Route of North Central Railway.	Chhata Km 1427/21 (Chainage 1427/507.80)	Chhata Km. 1427/29 (Chainage 1427/640.80)

684/26 (AS) Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Project North Central Railway, Agra

@ CPONCR North central railways cponcrfy CPONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

NIT No.	353390
Name of Work and its location	Tender for "Complete Stripping of Air brake pipeline, bending, threading of 25 NB Pipe for LHB coaches and fitment of complete axle mounted disc brake system including WSP of all type of LHB coaches during MLR schedule" at RCNK."
Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 4051362/- including GST (Rs. Forty Lakh Fifty-One Thousand Three Hundred Sixty-Two Only)
Earnest Money	Rs. 81000/-
Completion period of work	24 months from date of LOA
Cost of Tender document on cash/by post	NIL
Date and Time for submission of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs on 17.04.2026
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
Tender No.: 353390 Dated:- 27.03.2026	1037/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhattiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Abdul Majid S/o Abdul Rais, R/o: H.No. 350, Gali No.-2, Kadampuri, Gokulpuri, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 184/2023, U/S 135 Electricity Act, PS Jama Masjid, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Abdul Majid** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Abdul Majid** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Abdul Majid** the said accused of **FIR No. 184/2023, U/S 135 Electricity Act, PS Jama Masjid, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.04.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sunil Chaudhary
Special Judge Electricity Court-02,
Central, Room No.-408, Extension Block,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/3987/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Corrigendum

Tender Notice No. 93/2025-2026 dated: 13.03.2026

S.No. 01 Tender Number 12255003D Due date 30.03.2026

In reference to above due date of the Tender has been extended from 30.03.2026 to 06.04.2026 till 11:00 AM. All other Terms and Conditions remain unchanged.

The Corrigendum has been published on Website www.ireps.gov.in

Date: 27.03.2026 1047/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

POLICE FAMILIES WELFARE SOCIETY, DELHI

PHQ BUILDING, JAI SINGH ROAD, NEW DELHI

APPOINTMENT NOTICE

Applications are invited for engagement of the following posts on Honorarium Basis for Smita Therapy Centre, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi and Kiran Therapy Centre, NPL, Kingsway Camp Delhi:-

Posts:

- * **01-Speech Therapist** for Smita Therapy Centre, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi.
- * **01-Occupational Therapist** for Kiran Therapy Centre, New Police Lines, Kingsway Camp Delhi.

Essential Qualifications: Graduate/Diploma in Speech Therapy/Occupational Therapy with minimum 02 years of experience.

Additional Requirements:

- Preference will be given to candidates having experience of working with children with special needs.
- Qualification must meet the minimum standards prescribed by the **Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI)**.
- Candidate must be registered with RCI.

How to Apply:

Eligible candidates may send their application along with self-attested copies of educational and professional documents to email: inspr.welfare@gmail.com. Latest by **03.04.2026 (up to 6:00 PM)**

Interview details will be communicated to shortlisted candidates only.

DP/9872/Welfare/2026

GOVERNMENT OF CHHATTISGARH, WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

KHARUNG WATER RESOURCES DIVISION BILASPUR, DISTT. - BILASPUR (C.G.)

e-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

eProcurement Portal: <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>

(FIRST CALL)

NIT No.: 34,35,36 /SAC/2025-26 Dated: 25.03.2025

Online Tenders are invited for the following works up to 15.04.2026 at 17:30 Hour

01.Name of work :- RENOVATION AND CONSTRUCTION OF C.C. LINING & STRUCTURE'S OF PARAGHAT MINOR, BHILAI MINOR -01 AND PARAGHAT DISTRIBUTORY OF KHARUNG TANK SCHEME.

Tender System No. 187674 , Probable Amount of Contract: - Rs. 270.85 Lakhs (Excluding GST) (Contract based on SOR 01.05.2025 with amendment 08.08.2025)

02.Name of work :- REPAIR OF CC LINING OF PATHARTAL MINOR, JAIPUR MINOR, OKHAR MINOR AND KHAPRI DISTRIBUTARYAND RECONSTRUCTION OF VRB AT RD 2640 M OF JAIPUR MINOR, 02 NOS FALL AT RD 150 M & RD 360 M OF OKHAR MINOR, HEAD REGULATOR OF OKHAR MINOR UNDER KHAPRI DISTRIBUTARY OF LBC MAIN CANAL OF KHARUNG TANK SCHEME.

Tender System No. 187675 , Probable Amount of Contract: - Rs. 264.17 Lakhs (Excluding GST) (Contract based on SOR 01.05.2025 with amendment 08.08.2025)

03.Name of work :- REPAIR, MAINTENANCE AND FURNISHING WORK OF KHUTAGHAT IB & STRENGTHENING OF LBC C.C. ROAD OF KHARUNG TANK SCHEME.

Tender System No. 187677 , Probable Amount of Contract: - Rs. 164.79 Lakhs (Excluding GST) (Contract based on SOR 01.05.2025 with amendment 08.08.2025)

The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Chhattisgarh Integrated e-Procurement Portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) from Date **01.04.2026, at 17:31 Hours.(IST)** onwards.

NOTE :- 1- All eligible/interested contractors/bidders are mandated to get enrolled on the Integrated e-procurement portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) and get approval on specific vendor class from PWD under Centralized Contractor/Supplier Registration in order to download the tender documents and participate in the subsequent bidding process.

2- It is mandatory for the tenderer to use the certificate issued for Pre Bid Qualification (Valid up to 30.09.2026) in the year 2025 in this tender.

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
KHARUNG W.R. DIVISION
BILASPUR (C.G.)
Dated : 25.03.2026

G 252607422/3

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, hitherto known as Chhna Negi W/o U S Negi R/o House No. K-3/37 Street No -12 West Ghonda Delhi Dist North East Delhi- 110053 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Channa Devi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Mukesh Kumar, son of Pura, R/o House No. 331, Dhoobi Mohalla, Village Chandawali, District Faridabad, have disinherited my son, Devendra, and daughter-in-law, Mrs. Anupama, who, beyond my control, have been abusive and have behaved indecently. Anyone dealing with them in the future will be held responsible.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No.: S/Sale/611E-AP/170758/2026-27 Dated 27.03.2026

First Corrigendum in e-auction notice no. 01

Following the approval of the competent authority, the e-auction program to be organized by the Deputy Chief Material Manager/System/Jhansi in April 2026 has been rescheduled. The auctions previously scheduled for 07.04.2026 (Tuesday) and 14.04.2026 (Tuesday) will now be held on 09.04.2026 (Thursday) and 16.04.2026 (Thursday), respectively.

All other dates and terms & conditions of the e-auction programme will remain unaltered.

569/26 (D)

North central railways @ CPONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

विशेष शाखा, पुलिस मुख्यालय, मध्य प्रदेश भोपाल

क्रमांक:- विशा/स्टोर/2026-24 (156), दिनांक:-25/3/2026

संभावित सेवा प्रदाताओं/पात्र एवं सक्षम सविदाकर्ताओं की पहचान सूचीबद्ध करने हेतु विज्ञापन-सूचना:-

शिलालेख वर्ष 2026-27 में आगामी एक वर्ष में मरम्मत/स्वच्छता, सेवाएं प्राप्त करने हेतु संभावित सेवा प्रदाताओं/पात्र एवं सक्षम सविदाकर्ताओं की पहचान सूचीबद्ध करने हेतु फर्म निम्नानुसार बिन्दुवार जानकारी इस कार्यालय में दिनांक 15.04.2026 समय- 16.00 बजे तक वार्षिकता रूप से जमा करें।

ई-मेल, डाक द्वारा प्राप्त प्रस्ताव स्वीकार नहीं किए जाएंगे।

1- फर्म का नाम, 2- फर्म का पंजीयन प्रमाण पत्र, 3- फर्म का पूरा पता, 4- वार्षिक टर्नओवर, 5- जीएसटी नम्बर, 6- मुकदमा, 7- जासकीय/ अवैधता/अवैधता संख्या में उपरोक्त कार्य करने हेतु संश्लेषित दस्तावेज/अनुभव प्रमाण पत्र, 8- संस्थान, दुकान के फोटोग्राफस मरम्मत/स्वच्छता हेतु कार्यालयीन उपकरणों, फर्नीचर, साज-सज्जा लाईटिंग कार्य की जानकारी

क्रमांक	कार्य का प्रकार	उपकरण का नाम
1	समस्त कार्यालयीन उपकरणों के मरम्मत कार्य	कम्प्यूटर रिपैरिंग, प्रिंटर रिपैरिंग (क्लेक एण्ड हाईट, कलर) फोटोकॉपी मशीन रिपैरिंग, फेक्स मशीन रिपैरिंग, टी.वी रिपैरिंग, लेपटॉप रिपैरिंग, एम्पल मेक यूपीएस, इन्वर्टर सिलिफेन, वालफेन कुलर मरम्मत एसी मरम्मत प्रिंटर कार्टेज रिफिलिंग कार्य बायोमेट्रिक मशीन प्रोजेक्टर केबल रिवाइज
2	कार्यालयीन मरम्मत कार्य	फर्नीचर टेबल, कुर्सी, अलमारी आदि फर्नीचर सुधार कार्य
3	साज सज्जा	राष्ट्रीय त्योहारों एवं अन्य अवसरों पर शासकीय भवन में साज-सज्जा लाईटिंग कार्य। नवीन इटीग्रेटेड कमाण्ड कंट्रोल सेंटर श्यामला हिल्स भवन हेतु।

विस्तृत जानकारी एवं सेवा की सामान्य शर्तें म.प्र. पुलिस वेबसाइट पर उपलब्ध हैं।

उप पुलिस महानिरीक्षक विशेष शाखा गुप्तचर म.प्र. भोपाल

627917/25

"स्वभाव स्वच्छता, संस्कार स्वच्छता"

यूनियन बैंक ऑफ इंडिया

REGIONAL OFFICE - New Delhi, 1, Faiz Road, Jhandewalan, New Delhi-110005, E-mail : cb8821rec@unionbankofindia.bank

AUCTION NOTICE

For sale of Immovable Properties

FOR FURTHER DETAILS SCAN THE QR CODE

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable/Movable Assets on 30.04.2026 between 12:00 PM to 05:00 PM (with unlimited extension of 10 minutes each) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with Rule 8/9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule, 2002 Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged and charged to the Secured Creditor, the possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of Union Bank of India (secured creditor), will be sold on As is where is. As is what is and "Whatever there is" on the date mentioned below, for recovery of dues as mentioned hereunder to Union Bank of India from the below mentioned Borrower(s) & Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and the Earnest Money Deposit are also mentioned hereunder

S. No.	Name of the Branch	Name & address of Borrower & Guarantor	Details of Property	Constructive or Physical Possession taken	Total Dues	Reserve Price (in lakh)	Name & Contact No. of Authorized Officer
1	CHANDNI CHOWK BRANCH (30710)	1. M/s Noor International Address at: 6112/17, Ramdev Market, Kharibaoli, Delhi-110006 2.Mr. Mohammed Nadeem (Partner & LRS/Legal Heirs) Address at: 1110, Gali Samosan, Farash khana, Delhi-110006 3.Mr. Mohammad Imran (Partner & LRS/Legal Heirs) Address at: 1110, Gali Samosan, Farash khana, Delhi-110006 4.Ms. Nazreen (LRS/Legal Heirs) Address at: 1110, Gali Samosan, Farash khana, Delhi-110006	All that part and parcel of the property consisting of Five Commercial Shops, Property bearing MC no. 173, Ward no. VII, Masjid Tehwar khan Gali, Naya Bans, Chandni chowk, Delhi-110006 Bounded; On the North – Property no. VII/175-176 On the South - Gali On the East – Property no. VII/172(new) On the West - Gali	Physical	Rs. 27.73 lacs + Interest + Expense	93,00,000.00 9,30,000.00 1,00,000.00	Mr. Ajit Kumar Singh (8812006856)

BRIEF TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF E-AUCTION SALE :- The sale shall be subject to the Terms & Conditions prescribed in the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 and to the following further conditions : (1) The Properties are being sold on "AS IS WHERE IS BASIS" and "AS IS WHAT IS BASIS" and "WHATEVER THERE IS BASIS". (2) The particulars of Secured Assets specified in the Schedule herein above stated to the best of the information of the Authorised Officer, but the Authorised Officer shall not be answerable for any error, misstatement or omission in this proclamation. (3) The sale will be done through e-auction platform provided at the Website <https://ebkraj.in> on date and time of auction specified above. (4) Bank reserves the rights to cancel (postpone the auction at any point of time. (5) For further details and complete Terms & Conditions of the sale, please refer : <http://www.unionbankofindia.co.in/english/TenderViewAllAuction.aspx> (6). Interested person may also contact the concerned authorised officer.

Date: 27.03.2026 Place: New Delhi Authorised Officer, Union Bank of India

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AAMIR OPENS UP ABOUT 'SITAARE ZAMEEN PAR' OTT RELEASE

Khan also applauded Dhurandhar's box office run

Aamir Khan recently shared that the digital release of 'Sitaare Zameen Par' had always been part of the strategy, though not immediately after its theatrical run. The film, directed by R S Prasanna, hit cinemas in June 2025 and went on to earn over Rs 250 crore, receiving appreciation for its story and performances. It is now set to premiere on 'SonyLIV' on April 3.

Speaking about the timing, Aamir spoke to PTI, "I was never in two minds. I always wanted an OTT release, but not so quickly after the theatre release. So, it is now coming on 'SonyLIV' on April 3 and I want audiences all across the country to enjoy the film." He added, "Those who have not got a chance to see it in theatres can now watch it on 'SonyLIV'."

Interestingly, shortly after its theatrical release, 'Sitaare Zameen Par' took an unconventional route by premiering on Aamir's 'YouTube' channel under a pay-per-view model. The idea was to make the film more accessible while exploring alternative distribution methods beyond traditional OTT deals.

Explaining his approach,



Aamir had earlier said, "This is my private cinema chain. Think of it like 'Aamir Khan Productions' has opened a new cinema chain, which is in everyone's house and in everyone's pocket. I got good offers from OTT channels. But I don't want those Rs 100-125 crore from OTT channels."

"I want to earn Rs 100 from my audience. I prefer that more," he highlighted his focus on direct audience engagement.

The film serves as a follow-up to 'Taare Zameen Par', with Aamir playing Gulshan Arora, a basketball coach whose life takes an unexpected turn. After losing his

job, he is assigned to train a team of neurodivergent players as part of community service, eventually preparing them for a tournament. The narrative blends emotion with an inspiring journey of growth and acceptance.

Alongside the film, the documentary 'Sitaaron Ke Sitaare' will also be available on the platform. Speaking about it, Aamir said, "It's a very special piece of content because it looks at the real superstars."

Alongside 'Sitaare Zameen Par', the documentary 'Sitaaron Ke Sitaare' will also be available on the platform

The 'Sitaare' are the superstars, but the real-life superstars are the parents of these 10 artists who have raised them and have taken care of them. So that film really highlights the fact that the parents are the real superstars."

The actor also extended his support to 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', which has been performing strongly at the box office. "I believe it's doing really well. I have not seen the film yet, but I hear only praises for the films 'Dhurandhar' one and now part two. Both the films have done exceptionally well and my very best wishes to the team," Aamir remarked.

AGENCIES

'Dhurandhar 2' crosses Rs 1,088 crore globally

The film has registered all-time record collections across every single day of its first week

Aditya Dhar's 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' has crossed Rs 1,088 crore gross worldwide in its first week of release, making it one of the biggest blockbusters in Indian cinema history.

According to 'Jio Studios' and 'B62 Studios', the Ranveer Singh-starrer spy thriller collected Rs 814 crore gross in India and Rs 274 crore overseas in its eight-day opening week, taking the worldwide gross to Rs 1,088 crore. The film's net collection in India stood at Rs 690 crore for the week.

In a statement, the makers said 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' has registered all-time record collections across every single day of its first week.

"The sequel to the blockbuster 'Dhurandhar' has surpassed all previous benchmarks and established new records with the fastest run to Rs 1000 crores worldwide, the highest opening weekend and the strongest weekday hold ever recorded for an Indian film globally," the makers said.

The film had set the tone with a record-breaking opening weekend, collecting Rs 761 crore globally in its first four days. The momentum sustained through the weekdays, with the film collecting Rs 64 crore on Monday, Rs 58 crore on Tuesday, Rs 49 crore on Wednesday and Rs 53 crore on Thursday in India.

The film also became the first Indian film to cross the Rs 100 crore milestone in a single day in one language, earning Rs 145 crore (nett) combined in paid previews and on its opening day in India.



The film had set the tone with a record-breaking opening weekend, collecting Rs 761 crore globally in its first four days

A sequel to Dhar's 2025 blockbuster, the film released on March 19 in Hindi, Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam. It stars Singh alongside R Madhavan, Arjun Rampal, Sanjay Dutt, Sara Arjun and Rakesh Bedi.

Set in the Lyari town of Karachi, an area known for its history of gang wars and violent turf battles, 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' charts the rise of Singh's character Hamza Ali Mazari in the Karachi underworld while delving into his origins as Jaskirat Singh Ranghi, a young man who transforms into a covert operative. The film is produced by Jyoti Deshpande and Lokesh Dhar.

PTI

'VARANASI' IN TWO PARTS?

SS Rajamouli to split his new directorial

When SS Rajamouli crafted 'Baahubali' as a two-part movie, with the first film ending on a cliffhanger and leaving much unsaid, many were sceptical about whether it would work. However, the 'Baahubali' movies changed the landscape of Indian cinema, both for better and worse. While it gave filmmakers the confidence to dream big, it also ushered in a new wave where almost every big-ticket film is conceived as a multi-part, pan-India project. Unsurprisingly, many have backfired. Yet, the trend of franchise films continues unabated.

Meanwhile, it seems that Rajamouli, the man who launched this movement, is now set for another two-part film. According to a new report, his epic action-adventure 'Varanasi' will be released in two parts. Much like what director Aditya Dhar did with his 'Dhurandhar' movies, Rajamouli plans to split 'Varanasi' into two to narrate the entire expansive tale without butchering it to fit theatrical standards.

"Three hours-plus wouldn't be enough for 'Varanasi'. They are looking at extending it into a two-part format," a source familiar with the project's developments told 'Bollywood Hungama'. "Rajamouli and his team feel this extended format would afford them the liberty to tell a more expanded story without looking anxiously at the clock." The movie features Mahesh Babu, Priyanka Chopra and Prithviraj Sukumaran in the lead roles.

Although the narrative is set in the city of Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh, the Rajamouli directorial isn't being shot there. The filmmaker has created a massive replica of Varanasi in Hyderabad, the capital of Telangana, as the primary location for the movie. According to a 'Polygon' report, the makers have even recreated the Ratneshwar Mahadev temple for the shoot. A full-sized temple has also been built to serve as the backdrop for a few scenes set in the past and it will then be buried underwater for present-day sequences.

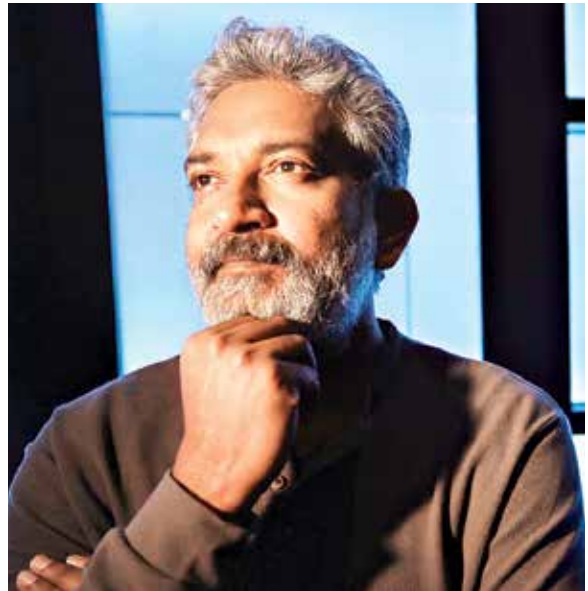
However, unlike Baahuba-

Interestingly, the movie unfolds across multiple timelines

It's sets, which remain a major tourist attraction at Ramoji Film City in Hyderabad to this day, Varanasi's sets will be demolished once production is complete, as the makers have erected them on a rented plot.

Interestingly, the movie unfolds across multiple timelines, including the present day and the year 512 CE. "It's not like you're sitting in a machine and going into... It's not 'Back to the Future'. But we do go from 7,200 BCE to 2027. So, you travel worlds and realms that our characters move within, which makes it really interesting. So, it is a time-travel movie," Priyanka Chopra Jonas told the publication..

AGENCIES



Tom Hanks reunites with Marielle Heller for a new movie

The project is an adaptation of 'The Comebacker'

Hollywood veteran Tom Hanks and director Marielle Heller are set to reunite for a baseball dramedy feature film. According to 'Variety', the project is an adaptation of 'The Comebacker', a short story by Pulitzer Prize finalist Dave Eggers, with Heller directing.

Hanks and Heller, who first collaborated for the 2019 Oscar-nominated film 'A Beautiful Day in the Neighbourhood', will also produce through their respective production banners. The movie has attracted multiple studio bidders, with 'Sony Pictures', which also released 'A Beautiful Day in the Neighbourhood', said to be in pole position to acquire the project.

Sources told the outlet that pop star Bad Bunny and Oscar nominee Colman Domingo are also in discussion to feature in the project. Bad Bunny, whose real name is Benito Antonio Martinez



Ocasio, is currently on a world tour running through the end of July, while Domingo's involvement is also at an early stage.

Eggers' work has previously served as source material for two other Hanks films - 'A Hologram for the King' (2016) and 'The Circle' (2017).

Hanks and Heller first collaborated for the 2019 Oscar-nominated film 'A Beautiful Day in the Neighbourhood'

'The Comebacker', which is the first short in Eggers' collection titled 'The Forgetters', follows Lionel, a fading sports journalist whose passion for his craft is reignited by a minor league pitcher called up to the majors.

The pitcher, who suffered a skull injury from a ball hit back at him, subsequently exhibits unusual behaviour, including poetic speech that gives Lionel's writing new resonance. The story is set around the 'San Francisco Giants', though the screenplay is expected to revolve around the 'New York Mets'.

PTI

'KAPTAAN' TEASER

In a world where power rules, 'Kaptaan' takes charge

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player' unveiled the teaser of its upcoming series 'Kaptaan', a hard-hitting cop drama set in the heart of Jwalabad. Headlined by Saqib Saleem as SSP Samardeep, a celebrated supercop and encounter specialist with a past he can't outrun, the series also boasts a stellar cast featuring Siddharth Nigam, Kavita Kaushik, Varun Badola, Anjum Sharma, Aarif Zakaria, Pooja Gor, Vikram Kochhar and Anushka Kaushik in pivotal roles. Produced by Pammi Baweja and Harman Baweja and directed by Jatin Wagle, 'Kaptaan' dives into a world where power, crime and personal vendettas are deeply intertwined.

The teaser takes us into the intersecting worlds of SSP Samardeep and Kabir. Samardeep is an encounter specialist who follows his own code, one that leans more towards justice than the rulebook, while Kabir is a relentless force driven by



The new 'Amazon MX Player' series stars Saqib Saleem, Siddharth Nigam, Kavita Kaushik and many others

nexus at play. As the situation spirals, the kaptaan steps in to restore order, while rival forces led by Anjum Sharma and Aarif Zakaria edge closer to a violent face-off. With the city on the brink and tensions at an all-time high, will he be able to bring it all under control?

Produced under the banner of 'Baweja Studios', 'Kaptaan' will stream soon for free exclusively on 'Amazon MX Player', available across mobile devices, connected TVs, Amazon's shopping app, 'Prime Video', 'Fire TV', 'Jio TV' and 'Airtel Xstream'.

Ryan to lead new film for 'Everything Everywhere All at Once' directors

'Universal Pictures' has set the untitled sci-fi action comedy for November 19, 2027

Hollywood star Ryan Gosling will headline the next feature film from 'Everything Everywhere All at Once' directors Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert.

'Universal Pictures' has set the untitled sci-fi action comedy for November 19, 2027, release with production set to begin in Los Angeles this summer, according to 'The Hollywood Reporter'. The casting deal closed just days after Gosling's latest blockbuster, Amazon MGM's 'Project Hail Mary', surpassed box office expectations, grossing USD 100 million in North America and USD 155 million worldwide.

Plot details remain under wraps, though Kwan offered some details of the story during an interview with 'Collider' on the sidelines of the South By Southwest Festival.

"Fun sci-fi, action comedy with a big heart. Very existential. All those things



The film is the follow-up to 'Everything Everywhere All at Once', the 2022 critical and commercial phenomenon

that you would hope that one of our movies would be," he said. He added the film would reckon with a 'complex' world, saying the duo's desire to 'reconcile all those things and put them into one movie' had

extended their timeline.

The film is the follow-up to 'Everything Everywhere All at Once', the 2022 critical and commercial phenomenon that earned over USD 100 million at the box office and won seven Oscars, including 'Best Picture', 'Best Director', 'Best Actor (Female)' for Michelle Yeoh and 'Best Original Screenplay'.

Kwan and Scheinert, collectively known as Daniels, made their feature debut with 2016's 'Swiss Army Man', a fantasy comedy starring Paul Dano and Daniel Radcliffe.

The film marks Gosling's second major 2027 release, alongside 'Star Wars: Starfighter', director Shawn Levy's spinoff in which the actor is also set to appear. They will produce the movie alongside their longtime producing partner, Jonathan Wang, through Playgrounds' banner, which operates under an overall deal with 'Universal'.

PTI

